pour your wine on (holy fires that you fled)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/27173129.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
POV Adora (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, adoptee trauma, facial scarring, Blindness, Scarring, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Trauma, Past Child Abuse, Chronic Pain, Adopted Children, Adopted Sibling Relationship, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Oblivious Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Princess Catra (She-Ra), Jealous Catra (She-Ra), they go on a BOAT, no one in this ever talks about a goddamn thing, adora takes everything the wrong way, it's a disaster, Unreliable Narrator, you really cant trust a word adora says at any given moment, really they're all constantly lying to eachother, and themselves, and you, readers: with adora and catra both on the same side surely the horde will lose!, shadow weaver coming out of her well to shame mankind, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Alternate Universe - Canon, Canon Universe, Alternate Canon, Canon Gay Relationship, Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Heavy Angst

Language:
English

Series:
Part 3 of is it not better to live (turn the stones into bread)

Stats:
Published: 2020-10-26 Completed: 2021-01-18 Words: 21,494 Chapters: 7/7

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by womenlovingwonderwoman (The_Camel_Queen)

Summary

"I'm sorry I stared," George said after what felt like eons. "I just—I knew someone else who had scars like those."

Adora's hand tightened over the book, her breath coming out in harsh gasps. *He knows he knows he knows he knows he knows he knows he knows*

"They were on his back though."

Adora's brow furrowed, "His back?"

George nodded, "He never said where he got them. Told me it was an accident he had as a child."

"I have some on my back too," Adora said. And her arms, her legs, and running up her neck.

"It wasn't an accident, was it," George said.

Adora looked back down at the book and elected not to answer. George sighed and walked a little ways away, out of earshot of Adora's pounding heart.

Who was he? She thought all this time that it was just her but what if—what if Shadow Weaver had others? Should she feel relieved? Betrayed?

She just felt numb.

Catra was arguing with Glimmer about something, Adora couldn't tell what. The gray tufts behind her ears looked soft. Adora looked down at the book again and pretended to read it.

or:
the most visible scars on Adora are not the most painful, nor the most debilitating. The war isn't over yet.

Notes

I said I would write a one shot series and now I'm writing a sequel and it'll probably have a brother before this series ends. But keep checking that damn one shots series bc I have some updates that are set to go on that puppy soon enough.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Her leg screamed. A smell like burning flesh invaded Adora's senses as that familiar electric crackling pulsed around her. She gritted her teeth, walking through the pain as she kept pace with the rest of the group. This was one of the first missions the queen had let her go on and she was not gonna fuck it up because of a stupid twinge in her leg.

"Hold up," Catra called from behind them. Her tail dragged on the ground a little, her breath coming out in gasps. "Let's—"

Bow was already stopped, reaching into Glimmer's bag for a canteen. He passed it to Catra and she took a few harsh gulps. Adora leaned against the side of the mountain, trying to look nonchalant as she finally took some weight off her leg. She was sweating way more than normal, but Bow was too focused on Catra to notice anything.

If she kept up like this she wouldn't be able to sleep tonight but that was nothing new. This was all her fault anyway. She made the mess so she had to clean it up.

"We've got another mile to go," Bow told them, examining his tracker.

They would've taken horses but they needed to be stealthy. Plus, Adora couldn't ride one and they freaked Glimmer out. At least, according to Bow. Glimmer hadn't said one way or another. Adora wasn't positive what a horse was, probably their word for skiff. Like how Bow called it a tracker and she had called it a scanner. Or how Catra had mentioned her "aunt" Casta once which probably meant ally.

"Once we get there we'll need to be quick. Catra, you'll be—"

"I'll be fine," Catra cut Glimmer off, and took another swig from the water. "Just follow your part of the plan and I'll follow mine."

They'd been marching all morning. Hiking, Bow had called it. Another example. The weather was fair, 83 degrees with a slight breeze from the northwest corridor. Some cloud cover, but little chance of rain.

Adora glanced at the sky again. There were fewer clouds, still, they wouldn't want a storm interrupting a safe getaway. Though it might cover up tracks. Maybe they did want a storm. Should they have brought Mermista? No, Catra hated water.

Her leg rippled with unfelt pain and she nearly collapsed but leaned further against the mountain side instead.

Catra handed the canteen back to Bow who put it back in Glimmer's bag. She stretched out and nodded at Adora. Adora swallowed hard and pushed off the cliff side, taking care not to stumble and keep her expression straight. Once she turned into She-Ra the pain would fade, her vision would come back, she'd be fine. Everything would be fine.

Bow and Glimmer walked a little ahead of them and Catra walked beside her, trailing until Adora was forced to keep pace with her.

"This was a good idea," Catra said, her knuckles bouncing against Adora's.

Adora frowned—they hadn't even gotten to Dryl yet. "We'll know soon enough," she pointed out.

"I guess," Catra rolled her eyes. "But at least we're doing something. I don't think my mom ever really had a plan."

That had become very clear to Adora. The Horde's plan was simple: divide and conquer. Start with the princesses that controlled arable land, cut off the chain of supply, gradually transition to princesses with significant power. First Plumeria, Salineas, and Bright Moon. Save Snows until last because of the difficult winters.

The Rebellion's overarching plan held none of the same grandeur. Hold on, had been the basics of it, pray for a miracle, had covered the rest. And here she was, the miracle they'd been holding on for, and she was broken and useless and half-blind and caused most of the damage they were trying to right.

But Adora was smart and could and would be useful to them. She had to be.

"You have one now," Adora said quietly.

"We do," Catra reached for her hand and took it, her fingers sliding in between Adora's calloused and scarred ones. Adora blinked at them, and looked at Catra who looked like she was waiting for something. Were they supposed to kiss? They were walking… she squeezed Catra's hand and that seemed to cover it, as Catra smiled and looked ahead again.

The new Rebellion plan was mostly the same as the old one. Hold on until Adora could rustle up a miracle. AKA: recreate the princess alliance and get the numbers on their side again. Numbers were the Horde's biggest advantage; if they were at least comparable, they could slow the Horde's exponential encroach into the rebellion's lands.

Entrapta was step one. Plumeria and Salineas would be next, Kingdom of Snows last.

"So, what's Entrapta like?" Catra asked. "I've only heard Bow gush about her."

"Um," Adora tried to think about how one might describe Entrapta, about how a rebel might. If she were in the Horde she'd say Entrapta was an asset and leave it at that. But… well maybe Bow at least would frown at the wording. "She's—smart. About tech stuff. And, um, nice?" Entrapta was not very nice to her, but that's mainly because Adora was threatening her and her people. But Entrapta's people probably wouldn't have wanted her to be their princess if she was mean? Was that how it worked?

“Nice?” Catra asked, eyebrows raised.

Adora looked away, “I guess.”

“Hmm,” Catra bumped her shoulder, “Are you keeping secrets from me?”

Adora stumbled, pain shooting up her leg, and she put a hand on the mountain side, screwing her eyes shut, “No. No. I um—”

“Relax,” Catra sounded bored now. “C’mon, we can’t let Sparkles and Arrow Boy beat us to Dryl.” She kept her hand in Adora’s though, tight, like she knew Adora needed the leverage and Adora swallowed hard. She really was a terrible person. Weak.

They kept marching, catching up with Bow and Glimmer quickly who, oddly enough, weren’t really talking much to each other. They had gotten along fine the last time Adora talked to them. Had she said something wrong?

“What’s wrong?” Catra demanded.

“We were just saying,” Bow glanced at Glimmer, “It’s really quiet. For a Horde base.”

Adora blinked, he was right—she should have noticed—there should’ve been sounds of machinery, people shouting orders, the familiar groan of bots. Even the distant clink of miners shoveling should’ve been audible.

“We’re in an avalanche zone,” Catra pointed out. “They have to be quiet.”

Adora shook her head, “No it’s—when I was in charge,” she flinched, “it was never this quiet. It’s never been this quiet.”

How had she not noticed? Her leg, her eye, too wrapped up in herself—she needed to focus. Obviously they needed to revise the plan, it wouldn’t work now. They needed—

“Okay,” Catra squeezed her hand—they were still holding hands? —“We’ll do recon then. Glimmer and I will take a look around while you and Bow can be back up.”

“Um?” Bow looked between Glimmer and Catra who hadn’t met each other’s eyes all day.

Adora shook her head, “That makes no sense. I’m the only one who knows my way around Dryl.” That was the only reason Queen Angella let her go in the first place. “It has to be me.”

Catra released her hand, narrowing her eyes at Adora and Glimmer. “You’re about as stealthy as an elemental,” she said to Adora. “You guys would get caught in an instant.”

“So I’ll teleport us out,” Glimmer said. “C’mon Adora,” she held out her hand and Adora glanced at Catra who was now glaring. Catra still didn’t trust her, not with Glimmer. Of course.

Catra had assumed Adora had hurt Glimmer when she first joined the Rebellion, after all. And now she was assuming Adora couldn’t protect her. If Adora could leave Shadow Weaver behind, the closest thing she had to a mother, then maybe Catra was worried she could leave Glimmer. She’d have to prove otherwise.

Adora took the offered hand, her stomach instantly dropping out.

“You okay?” Glimmer asked, hand now touching her shoulder blade as Adora stumbled.

“Fine—fine.” She landed on her bad leg and had to prop herself up against the wall, hissing as she felt those old electric scars sear into her. It was all in her head, it wasn’t real, it was over, she had healed.

“Where are we?” Glimmer asked.

Adora looked around, taking in the compact quarters and the Horde insignia carved into the wall. “It’s a housing barracks. I

think civilian." She ran her fingers along the edge of a table, picking up a fair amount of dust.

Dryl was a dusty place, the lack of rain and huge amount of mining mixed together for an awful combination. People in Dryl liked things orderly though, calm, and no one would be caught dead with a speck of dust in their home. Most kids learned to clean before they learned to write their name.

"No one's been here for awhile," Adora said.

"Do you think the mines emptied out?" Glimmer asked.

Adora shook her head, "Unlikely. Besides they wouldn't have just… left." She leaned against a wall, edging around it to a nearby window and peeking out, wary of snipers. The whole square was deserted. The windows were empty. Dryl was a ghost town. "Let's head to the castle. Maybe I can find something in the records."

"Are you sure?" Glimmer was giving her a funny look and Adora stiffened. "You can take a break before we teleport again. It used to even give Bow vertigo."

"I'm fine. We don't have time to wait around." Adora held out her hand this time and Glimmer shrugged but took it. The sharp feeling of falling returned but this time Adora managed to stop herself from stumbling, merely closing her eyes to make the transition to new ground easier.

Something scuttled on her blind side. She whipped around, her sword drawn in one hand and Glimmer covered with the other.

"Oh," Adora looked at it. The bot was only six inches in diameter as it clicked around on 7 feet. Adora picked it up, examining it. "It's one of Entrapta's cleaning bots. Looks like one of the legs got pulled out." The wires didn't look cut, more ripped. "Probably a rat honestly."

Rats weren't really common in Dryl either. The elevation was pretty intense and the townspeople took to rats like a shark took

to blood. Apparently there had been some infestation a few decades ago, before the Horde even. When she had first been told about it Adora had been somewhat shocked. Rats were no uncommon thing in the Fright Zone but what really got to her was the second part. The "before the Horde" part. Sometimes it felt like the planet stopped and started with her.

She adjusted the grip on her sword. She was kinda right, in a way.

"You know, you're lucky it was me," Glimmer said.

Adora furrowed her brow and looked at Glimmer.

"Instead of Catra. If you had done the whole—" Glimmer made a serious face and then stuck a hand out wildly like she was trying to block someone, "—thing with Catra she would've clawed you." Glimmer rolled her eyes, "Cause Catra gets to be angry."

"Um," Adora set the bot down, letting it scuttle away. "Are you angry?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes, scarily reminiscent of Catra, "No. But you don't need to protect me."

Adora absolutely did. "Okay," her voice cracked and Glimmer scowled.

"So where should we check first?"

Adora straightened, she liked plans. "Her lab. Then her holding cell. From there we can go to the Base of Operations, and finally the barracks. If it's all as barren as this place is…"

"There's gotta be a lead somewhere. Ready to teleport?"

Adora shook her head, "We're better off walking. This place is too much of a maze."

Glimmer sighed, "Lead the way."

They hadn’t been walking long when Adora noticed how much Glimmer was staring at her. She kept sneaking glancing and then looking away and honestly it kind of made her skin itch. Adora had been hiding the limp pretty well, taking care to walk as close to the wall as possible so Glimmer wouldn’t have to see her horrifying facial scar, but they mostly hung out at night. Like, sleepovers or whatever Bow called them. Instead of just—sleeping. Maybe Glimmer still wasn’t used to the massive electrical scar that made her half blind.

“So you’re dating my sister.”

Adora tripped over thin air.

She just managed to right herself, double checking there weren’t any boobytraps before desperately calming herself so Glimmer wouldn’t see the rising blush.

“Um, I guess.”

“You guys get stuck in a First One’s ruin for a couple days and then she’s ready to bring you into the rebellion and date you?”

Glimmer sounded exactly like Queen Angella right now. It occurred to Adora this was the first time she’d hung out with Glimmer alone. For the most part, she and Bow were attached at the hip and Catra had really tried to check in with Adora a lot to make sure she was adjusting okay. Right now, Glimmer and Catra were a bit like opposing magnets.

“What do you even like about Catra?” Glimmer demanded, stepping closer.

“I—”

“How well could you even know her?”

“Really well!” Adora felt her mouth move before she could stop it. “I know that she cares about people a lot. More than anyone else I’ve ever met. She’s willing to do anything for the people she

loves. I know that she's smart and clever and always has eight different ways out of things and nine different new ideas before there's even a problem. I know that she's brave and isn't afraid to care about things or feel things and—and—she understands responsibility. And fear. And… and I guess me."

Glimmer's face was hard for only a moment longer before she cracked a smile, "Pretty good. I give you a B minus. Might want to work on it when you tell my mom all that."

"A what? Wait, what? Tell who?"

"Catra's going through a lot but my mom can't hate you forever. She'll get over it once she realizes you care about Catra."

"She should hate me. I killed her husband."

Glimmer looked her over, "You couldn't have been more than five."

"No, I mean, the Horde did."

Glimmer groaned, "Oh my god. And here I thought that finally Catra had found someone at her level. She usually goes for morons."

"Usually?" Adora asked. How many people had Catra dated? Did she care that Adora hadn't dated anyone? What did she—

Glimmer's eyes widened. "Um, which way did you say Entrapta's lab was again?"

They kept walking, but now Adora was the one stealing glances at her companion.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

something old, something soft, and a lie

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Empty," Glimmer announced, flipping over another crate.

Adora sighed, flipping through what was left of the files. Most of them had been burned to a crisp, and the data cores on all the computers had been wiped.

"Hey, there's still the barracks," Glimmer pointed out.

"This was all a waste of time," Adora shook her head. "Entrapta's not here, we should be back in Bright Moon, planning our next move, not sorting through a bunch of junk." She slammed the file cabinet closed, and the bang echoed around the room.

"Over a thousand people lived here; we need to find out what happened," Glimmer said.

Adora's stomach turned. How could she forget? She really was a terrible person, only focused on Entrapta, too selfish to think about the bigger picture.

"Do you think they would be taken to the Fright Zone?" Glimmer asked. "Like Dirk?"

Bow's brother had been taken during the Horde's assault on Alwyn. As far as they could tell most of his troops had been executed or sent with the civilians to various factories and mines. Dirk and a few of his superiors were taken to the Fright Zone. If that hadn't been enough to push the four of them into high gear, what they found when they arrived at Alwyn was.

The Horde had salted the earth.

With Alwyn being their main food provider, and the Horde controlling the majority of the remaining arable land, the Rebellion would be starved out before it was killed out. They had about a year, maybe two, before Queen Angella would be forced to surrender.

Entrapta was their best shot at any type of advanced weaponry, at balancing the scales even a little in terms of numbers. But Entrapta was gone, and Adora was a failure.

"There's too many of them. I don't know what the Horde would do," Adora said.

She knew exactly what the Horde would do. There were only so many factories, so many farms, so many mines, so many cells, so few rations.

Glimmer hummed, narrowing her eyes as she did it. "So where are the—"

Glimmer paused. Adora's hand settled on her sword, turning her entire body to face her, acutely aware of how vulnerable she now was with only half her field of vision.

"Bot? Horde soldier?" Adora muttered.

"Apple core," Glimmer walked over to a garbage bin, plucking it out as her features contorted with disgust. It was fresh.

"We're not alone," Adora said. She looked at the monitors, the cameras displaying every inch of the castle and its courtyard. "And we were being watched." She pulled out her staff, feet moving in a combat ready stance.

Glimmer shivered, "Are you always this dramatic? They couldn't have gotten far. You wanna…" Glimmer waved a hand at her.

“Oh,” Adora blushed, realizing the staff she had pulled out was actually a mystical sword of destiny that could turn her into an 8 foot tall glowing lady who could chew up a horde tank for breakfast. A lone Horde soldier was not really… a threat. “Right. No problem,” Adora swallowed. “For the honor of Grayskull!”

She felt the swirling tide of magic crescendo over her body, a warmth extending her limbs, her torso, even her hair. A healing wave poured over her face and both eyes glowed blue as Adora finally got a full field of vision.

Glimmer was staring at her, mouth open, eyes wide. Adora lowered her sword, aware that the sudden change in height had caused it to scrape the ceiling.

“What?” She asked.

Glimmer blinked and shook her head, “Where do you think they would’ve gone?”

“The weapons room, it’s easily defensible and a good spot to wait for backup.”

Glimmer furrowed her brow and glanced back around at the cameras, the single apple core. “You think they ordered backup.”

“Of course. That’s regulation.”

“Right.”

Glimmer was thinking and Adora shifted from foot to foot, wondering what the holdup was. “We could probably actually teleport, it’s not—”

“Where’s the barracks?”

“The other direction. Glimmer—”

“It’s just,” Glimmer frowned, “the only thing not visible here is the barracks, and the weapons room has blind spots but—I mean,

would anyone have been stationed here alone?”

“No, not unless they were a deserter.” Adora said, almost scoffing. That old habitual rage rose within her but she clenched her sword a little tighter, determined to ignore its irony. The Horde didn’t have deserters, it had dead traitors. She only survived because of Catra.

“We should split up: one of us goes to the weapons room, one of us to the barracks.”

Adora was already shaking her head, “No way.” Catra’d kill her.

“It’ll be fine, if I need help I can just teleport away,” Glimmer said.

Adora eyed her, she hadn’t known Glimmer long, but the prospect seemed unlikely.

Glimmer crossed her arms, “Do you really want to let them get away? I’ll go to the weapons room you can—”

“I’ll go to the weapons room,” Adora cut off. “You go to the barracks.”

Glimmer scowled and looked like she was about to stomp her foot. “Fine.”

Adora left the room first but kept a careful eye as Glimmer went down the corridor, making sure she turned the right direction and wouldn’t try and follow Adora. Hopefully Catra wouldn’t be too mad, especially if Adora caught the Horde soldier and Glimmer was kept very far from whatever scuffle inevitably occurred.

Probably wouldn’t last long though. Adora gave her sword an experimental swing, feeling the strength in her arms wield it in a way she normally wouldn’t have been able to. Maybe a few minutes, depending on who it was.

The castle was dull and lifeless as Adora marched through it. She kept expecting a killer robot to show up, like the first time she had

conquered Dryl. Conquered, Shadow Weaver had sneered, was giving Adora too much credit. She had practically rescued it. Once the infected chip had been destroyed, Entrapta taken safely into custody, all it had taken to get the rest of the castle staff on her side were the tape recorders. They numbered in the hundreds, if not thousands, and crushing one had made even the chef stop resisting.

Entrapta, similarly, stopped struggling when Adora even got close to those stupid recorders. It hadn't gotten the two of them off to a great start, to say the least.

Adora shook her head, trying to steady herself as she hugged a wall, even with her bulky stature, and transformed her sword into a shield. The weapons room was filled with long-range weaponry; Adora would have to block before she could attack. The shield thing had taken her forever to figure out—she had stayed up for three straight days just concentrating on turning the sword into things like Bow's dads said she should be able to.

Luckily, whoever it was who had been watching them had no idea who She-Ra was. They were in for a big surprise.

She swung around the corner, shield up, and kicked the door down.

To—an empty weapons locker.

Because—

Because even if someone had been stationed here alone they would not have gone to the weapons locker to hold off the enemy on their own—they would've gone to the barracks to hide.

Because—"Not everyone can be as strong as you," a voice hissed. "Some people are destined to be protected, others to protect."

Adora whipped around, sword up, but saw only an empty corridor and receding shadows.

“HORDE SOLDIER!” Glimmer shouted, her voice distant and desperate. There was the proof, right? Glimmer had known the Horde soldier would be at the barracks, let Adora think she wanted to go to the weapons room and—Adora took off running. She had failed to protect Glimmer, she was a failure she was—

“They’ll find out the truth soon enough,” a familiar voice called.

Adora ignored it. She just—

She rammed through the open door skidding into the barracks.

Glimmer was piggy back riding the Horde soldier’s back, covering the eyes of the soldier as they stumbled into walls.

“AAAHHH!”

“Let go of me!”

“Cadet Lonnie?”

Lonnie stilled and Glimmer slid off her back as Adora felt herself shrink into her normal form. “Force Captain Adora? What—what happened to you?”

Glimmer looked between them, “You two know each other?”

“Lonnie was—was placed in my squadron when I became a Force Captain,” Adora said.

Lonnie was staring at her, eyes wide and accusing, “You’re with the Rebellion now?”

Glimmer moved between them, getting in Lonnie’s face, “I ask the questions. Where’s Entrapta? Where are the townspeople? What happened here?”

Lonnie raised an eyebrow, “I’m terrified.”

At this Glimmer actually gasped, narrowing her eyes, as she summoned glowing balls of light at both of her hands.

“Oh yeah?”

Adora twisted the sword, easily bending it into golden rope. “Cooperate,” Adora said, tying Lonnie’s hands behind her back, “and maybe you’ll count yourself lucky that we found you before the Horde.”

Lonnie scoffed, “If you’re on the princess’s side now I don’t see how that’s possible.”

Adora tightened the restraints, feeling her stomach twist.

“That’s enough,” Glimmer said.

She grabbed Adora’s hand, giving it a quick squeeze and grabbed Lonnie by the forearm.

The vertigo set in but this time Adora didn’t even let herself close her eyes, only harshened her grip on Lonnie as Lonnie stumbled from the sudden jump.

“What the fuck?”

“That’s what you get, Horde scum,” Glimmer crossed her arms.

Adora looked around. They were near where they had first teleported, maybe only a fifteen minute walk away. She pushed Lonnie forward, “March, Cadet.”

“I ain’t your cadet.”

“March, then, prisoner,” Lonnie cast a glare back but marched ahead regardless. You could take the soldier out of the Horde, but you couldn’t take the Horde out of the soldier, Adora would guess.

“So I’m guessing you two weren’t friends?” Glimmer muttered.

“I told you: we didn’t have friends in the Horde.”

“What about Entrapta?”

Adora clenched her hands into fists, “She was my prisoner.” She wished they had had some other rope to tie Lonnie up with. She felt naked without her sword.

They only had to walk another five minutes before Catra slid down the cliffside, landing perfectly in front of them. “Oh look, tweedle dee and tweedle dumb are back. And you brought tweedle dumber.” She smirked at Lonnie, letting a fang flick out, “I don’t believe we’ve had the pleasure.”

“This is—”

“AHH!” Bow skidded down now too, following catra and using an arrow unsuccessfully to slow his dissent. Adora grabbed him by the shirt collar, righting him. He dusted himself off and glared at Catra.

“That’s why you’re not supposed to cut across switchbacks!”

“Well not everyone’s as useless as you,” Catra shrugged. She turned back to Adora, “What happened to doing recon?”

“I captured a Horde soldier,” Glimmer puffed out her chest. “Isn’t that way better?”

“Wait—” Catra’s eyes narrowed at Glimmer, “What do you mean you captured her?” She turned on Adora.

“It was a team effort?” Adora tried.

“We’ll talk about this later,” Catra promised.

“Don’t get mad at her,” Glimmer had her arms crossed. “At least she trusts me!”

Catra’s eyes widened, “Oh! If you want trust—”

“Hi, I don’t think we’ve met, I’m Bow!” Bow had his arm outstretched and Lonnie raised an eyebrow at him, then at the hand, then at him again, and then at Adora.

“You ditched us for them.”

“She was alone?” Catra’s eyes narrowed, examining and picking apart Lonnie the way she did all threats. The way she did Adora when they first met. Had she ever stopped? Was Adora sure?

Adora nodded, “The entire place was empty except for her.”

Catra glanced Lonnie over and Lonnie glared back. “C’mon, I know a place,” she said to the group.

Catra brought them to a defunct empty mine Adora recognized. It was a dead end she had once wasted an hour investigating but it was, conceivably, the best place to interrogate a prisoner. It was dark and remote and isolated. Someone could lose all sense of time in here. Not that they really had time to lose.

She leaned against a wall as they secured Lonnie around some old equipment the Horde had left behind. Mostly broken old tank parts. Her leg was aching from the walk and she tried to covertly rub out the pain. She hadn’t had a bad day like this in a while, and never for so long. It was the Rebellion; the soft cushy beds, the food, their hugs; she was getting weaker.

“Adora.” She straightened, having to turn fully to face Catra with her bad eye. “What the hell happened in there? You let Glimmer fight a Horde soldier alone?”

“No! No. Of course not,” Adora tried to brace herself on the wall, felt her knuckles turn white with the effort of keeping herself upright. “We split up when we realized there was someone else there.”

“Oh, because that makes sense,” Catra crossed her arms.

“I sent her to go—to go where I didn’t think Lonnie would be. But then Lonnie was there. I’m—” her breath cut out as her leg spasmed and her hand, now slick with sweat, slid against the wall. Warm hands caught her and she gripped them tightly.

“Where,” Catra demanded urgently, voice soft.

“Left leg.”

“Can you walk outside?”

“Yes.”

She felt Catra’s hands guide her outside the cave and settle her against the wall.

“Show me,” came the soft order and Adora rolled the cuffs of her long pants only enough to reveal the edge of the massive scar tucked away there.

“And that goes all the way up?” Catra asked. Adora looked away. “And it still hurts?”

“Sometimes.”

“You should’ve told me, told someone. Bow, my mom, even Glimmer,” Catra put a hand on her shoulder, sitting next to her. “I said I wanted to be there for you.”

Adora met her eyes. The crystal castle felt so long ago now but—but Adora had meant what she said then. About wishing she could’ve been there for Catra when she needed her. And maybe Catra meant it too, about wishing she could’ve been there for Adora.

Adora had only joined the rebellion to save Etheria, but she wouldn’t be able to limp her way to victory, half-blind and aching. Not alone, anyways. She was too weak.

“Adora, you have to tell me these things. Promise. Promise me you’ll talk to me, you’ll let me help.”

Adora looked down at her feet, she wasn’t supposed to need help. She was supposed to help. “Only if—” she looked back at Catra

and summoned whatever fortitude she had, “Only if you promise to let me help you.”

“I’m not the one nearly collapsing in a—”

“With Glimmer. You don’t trust me to protect her,” Catra opened her mouth to argue but Adora placed a hand over hers and blinked in surprise when Catra’s mouth shut. She’d have to—she’d have to remember that. “I understand needing to protect someone, better than anyone. But you said it yourself that I couldn’t do it alone. Catra, I promise I’ll never let anything happen to her.”

“Would you protect her over me?” Adora’s brow furrowed, “It’s war, Adora. It’s gonna happen.”

“I—maybe. Yes. Yes, I would. I’d—I’d do what you told me. Or whatever would—I don’t know. I don’t know.” God no. Adora would never. She looked away.

Catra sighed. “It was the last thing he asked me to do, Adora.” Her dad, King Micah, the commander before Catra. Adora still remembered the vision they had at the crystal castle of him, his kind eyes, the way he looked at Catra and at Glimmer. The way Catra looked at him. The way she looked when she thought of him now.

“I know. But aren’t you—aren’t you mad at him?”

“I still owe him. And I—I owe my mom. And Glimmer, I guess.”

“Glimmer kicked Lonnie’s ass.”

“Wait,” Catra’s brow furrowed. “That’s Lonnie? The one who beat you?”

“Once!”

“Damn,” Catra whistled. “Go Glimmer.”

"I sent her to check out where I thought there wouldn't be a dangerous Horde soldier," Adora said. "I—I was trying to keep her out of it. But she can—she can handle herself now, I think. And she isn't alone either. Bow and I will keep an eye on her. You aren't alone, I mean."

"She's my stupid sister," Catra said.

"Well, it's my stupid leg." And back, and hands, and eye.

Catra frowned.

"Just—I'll look out for you and you look out for me. And as long as we're—you know—um—together," Adora felt heat rise to her face and Catra's lips quirked up, "nothing really bad can happen."

"I—okay. Fine. I'll work on it."

Adora smiled, and Catra's hand fell to the cuff of her shirt, pulling her in, "You promi—um—"

Catra kissed her again.

It was really… soft? Soft things weren't really allowed in the Horde. Even the people were all hard edges and anger. The first time she had seen Catra, she had thought she was dreaming, a person made entirely out of whatever the opposite of the Horde's rigidity was. It was like a black hole existed in her mind's eye where Catra stood in front of her, helping her escape the collapsing temple. Something that shouldn't, couldn't, exist.

And now Catra let her kiss her.

Her entire body relaxed, she put a hand on Catra's thigh, waving the other a bit until it found a home on her shoulder. Catra grinned against her mouth and pulled away, laughing.

"You're such an idiot. I promise."

"Aww!"

Adora’s heart moved to her neck and she reached for her sword—gone!—her knife in her—

“Geez Bow, you gave me a heart attack!”

Bow pulled out his heart-shaped arrow. “I most certainly did not give you one of these.”

Catra rolled her eyes, “What do you want, Arrow Boy?”

“We’re interrogating the prisoner now? If you want to…” he gestured back and Catra rolled her eyes, turning to look at Adora.

“You ready?” Catra asked, Adora nodded.

Catra helped her to her feet, allowing Adora to put as much weight as she liked on her, and not even letting an inch of it show on her face. She was doing the same thing this morning, Adora realized. The dragging her feet, the holding her hand, it was all to get Adora to slow down. Catra had known something was wrong. How could Catra still care about her? How could she not be utterly disgusted by her? How did she deserve this?

Catra kept holding her hand as they followed Bow into the cave. She gave Adora a quick grin and Adora felt her heart stutter. She’d figure it all out later: for now she had a prisoner to interrogate, an Entrapta to free, and a planet to save.

Chapter End Notes

> me: sure this au has an angsty premise but it's really just meant to underscore how terrible shadow weaver was and explore catra and adora's characters. i mean, in the end it's actually a lot lighter than the show. glimmer and catra get to be sisters, adora and catra get together a lot sooner, angella lives, micah and her reunite--
> me: why--why is there a draft called coronation
> me: what--what's going on. why. why is there a draft called coronation. there's not gonna be a portal this time there couldn't be why is one of your drafts called coronation why

does there need to be a coronation
me to me: >:) it's not till later
me: wHAT

Well that's chapter 2 folks! Huge thanks to my coworkers who gave me enough serotonin while writing this that i managed to write what iamasecret called my best scene ever. also of course huge thanks to her for like... making this legible.

i'll have the next chapter up whenever i can, my work has chilled out somewhat but i might be moving? it's unclear. i do have a significant amount of the next chapter written but i hate it so im probs gonna rewrite it. If you comment im still gonna write 500 words. As you can see i've upped the chapter count. This is actually an underestimation, as i'm not sure how long we'll be on a boat or on vacation.

oh and keep sending me asks on tumblr! a lot of people have been sending me asks so there's all sorts of cool stuff there about the story under the tag bid my mother

you can send me asks on tumblr at @womenlovingwonderwoman
you can find iamasecret on tumblr at @iamasecret or here at iamasecret where she is writing a pacific rim au that I am bettaing but dont tell her i posted this bc i haven't finished looking at all her chapters bc she's a fucking monster and writes so much so fast and anyway it's called total synergistics and i've cried thrice

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> everyone is presented with enough data and information and still comes to the wrong conclusions about everything always.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"So you want to do this, or should I?" Catra muttered as they stepped in.

At the age of twelve every Horde soldier went through a course on interrogations. How to survive one, how to perform one, and how to watch one. Everyone had a tell, they were told, the key was to find it before the other person could hide it.

Adora's tell was simply her absolute inability to lie. Shadow Weaver had tucked her in that night, not even disappointed, and told her there were other ways of getting through an interrogation.

In the morning, Adora had learned them. She had learned silence the way kids her age learned how to rock climb or get a perfect score on the firing range. But what was worse was having to learn the other side too. She doesn't remember who she was paired with to "interrogate," can't even remember their face.

Adora squared her shoulders, "I can."

"That's not what I asked," Catra said, gripping her hand tighter and forcing her back against the wall. Adora barely struggled but. Still. Catra couldn't just—"Do you want to," Catra demanded.

"I've been trained, I know how to do this, I can do it," Adora argued.

“Adora,” Catra rubbed her eyes, “What was my question?”

“You asked if I could do it.”

“No.”

“Fine, what was your question?”

“Do you *want* to do it.”

Adora rolled her eyes. Semantics. “Catra, you’re being ridiculous. I’ll just do it.”

“Oh my god.” Catra put a hand on Adora’s shoulder and pushed her back against the wall.

Catra was—very close now. Her hand hadn’t left Adora’s shoulder. She was—she was touching her a lot, huh. That was. She was touching her a lot. Oh, Adora’s hands were on Catra’s waist.

“Adora,” Catra’s voice was very quiet, “Do you want to do it. Not ‘can you,’ not ‘will you,’ not ‘should you.’ I already know you can and you would. Do you want to?”

Catra was really warm under Adora’s hands. Why was she letting her touch her? Was she just—did she just like it? Adora was letting Catra touch her. Did Adora like it?

“Adora,” Catra stepped closer and—oh god, that made it worse.

“No—no—I mean—no, I don’t—I don’t want to,” Adora heard herself stutter out.

“Okay,” Catra nodded, “that’s fine.”

Adora nodded back, kinda numb. Catra squeezed her shoulder, softly. Adora wondered if she was gonna cry, if that was what would happen.

“Arrow Boy,” Catra called, “I’m going to interrogate the prisoner.”

He shrugged. “Okay.”

Glimmer crossed her arms and leaned against the wall, as Catra strode forward, easily taking a seat facing Lonnie on one of the chairs they had found in the piles of old Horde stuff. Lonnie was still tied up with that golden rope, and Adora’s hands itched to have it back, to carefully craft it back into the shackle on her wrist for convenience.

Catra faced Lonnie, glaring, and Bow began to pace.

Neither of them said a word, locked in a dead stare-off. Adora walked closer, stopping until she was just towering above Catra, and Lonnie’s eyes shot to her before looking back at Catra.

“So,” Catra drawled, examining her nails as she leaned back against the chair. “I can’t say Adora’s told me very much about you.”

“I know all about you,” Lonnie muttered.

“Oh yeah?” Catra moved onto her other hand, frowning as she picked away at some dead skin.

Lonnie spat at the ground in front of her, turning her ire on Adora. “You’re all selfish traitors. Traitors to Etheria. You don’t care about people, you only care about yourselves and your magic.” Adora stepped back, hands clenching into fists as her heart pounded in her ears.

“Uh huh,” Catra said. “You must really hate the Rebellion.”

“I won’t rest until you all—”

“So why’d you leave the Horde?” Lonnie went still, mouth clamping shut. Catra didn’t look up at her. “I mean. C’mon. Stationed alone, taken prisoner willingly, what are we supposed to think, Alonso?”

“Lonnie.”

“Leona?”

“Lonnie.”

“What am I saying?”

“Leona.”

“And what are you saying?”

“Lonnie.”

“I don’t hear a difference,” Catra shrugged. “So what’s your plan, Leonard?”

Lonnie glared, mouth drawn shut again. Adora put her hands on the backrest of Catra’s chair, Lonnie only spared a glance at her before refocusing back at Catra.

“I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

“Well,” Catra finally looked up, “You have some options. You can stay in Dryl until we conquer it again and you’re taken prisoner. Right now you caught me on a good day, but a couple months from now? Facing a famine, well, ‘hangry’ will be putting it mildly.”

Lonnie set her jaw.

“Of course you could run, but with She-Ra’s sword you wouldn’t get far,” Catra continued. “We could drop you back off at the Horde of course, tell them you’ve changed your mind.” She turned back to Adora.

“Anything I’m forgetting?”

“She could tell us where Entrapta is,” Adora’s voice came out a lot lower than she was expecting. The metal around Catra’s chair where she had been gripping it was bent.

“Oh *yeah* ,” Catra nodded and turned back to Lonnie. Her eyes narrowed, “You could tell us where Entrapta is.”

Lonnie didn’t take the bait, merely lifted her chin. “What’s in it for me?”

Catra leaned closer, voice dropping, “I keep wondering, why *were* you in Dryl? Just sitting there. Waiting to be captured. It’s so convenient, for us, I mean.”

“The Horde wouldn’t go back to a station they abandoned,” Lonnie said.

“Oh I’m sure,” Catra crossed her arms, “but there’s something else. You leave the Horde and then run away to Dryl? No one was there waiting for you. We would’ve captured them, too. ”

Lonnie glanced away and Adora’s heart raced, “You were waiting for someone,” Adora blurted. “You were—you were waiting. It was a rendezvous point.”

“No! We were—I was—”

Catra smirked, “So here’s the deal, Lennie: you tell us where Entrapta is, and we give you and whoever you were waiting for immunity. No matter where in the Rebellion you cowards tuck your tail between your legs at night, you’ll be safe.”

Lonnie blinked rapidly. “Really. You swear.”

“On my father’s grave,” Catra held up a hand.

“Entrapta’s on Beast Island,” Lonnie said.

The ground fell out from under Adora.

Her leg spasmed, and it was only by gripping Catra's chair that she managed to stay upright. “What—but—” Adora stared wide-eyed at Lonnie. “Why? No. No she couldn’t have—what did she do? Why would they—they wouldn’t have—why—” Catra’s hand was at her arm. Bow’s at her other.

“Hey,” Catra was trying to say something to her but Adora couldn’t stop staring at Lonnie, at the look and total complete disgust she was wearing. She knew it too. Everyone knew it. Soon even Catra would. It was Adora’s fault. It had to have been.

“What’s Beast Island?” Glimmer asked.

“Adora knows,” Lonnie said.

Adora swallowed hard. “It’s—it’s where we send the worst. People who try to organize the mining yards or factories, rebel generals who won’t cooperate, deserters. No one ever comes out of there alive.” She could feel Bow on her side tightening up, like a drawstring pulled taut.

“Do you know where it is?” Glimmer asked Lonnie.

“I don’t, but Adora used to take people there all the time.”

Adora swallowed hard, looking down.

“As fun as this has been,” Catra spat at Lonnie, “I think we’re done here. We’ll call for backup and they’ll take you back to Bright Moon.”

Lonnie’s face went slack and Adora had to turn to look at Catra, her eye obscuring the woman’s facial expression.

“You said I had immunity.”

“I lied.”

“Your—your father’s grave!”

“My father doesn’t have a grave. Horde didn’t leave us enough to bury.” Catra shrugged. “The prisons at Bright Moon are pretty nice though, I think. I’m sure Bow’s brother Dirk will be able to give us a good comparison when we get back from Beast Island with him.”

“He’s not in—” Lonnie’s mouth slammed shut.

Bow nearly crumpled at Adora’s side. “Thank god.”

Queen Angella was unhappy when they called her on the tracker for backup, full of lectures and arguments and chastisement.

Adora—hadn’t really gotten used to the queen yet. She gave orders but only with the hope that they’d be fulfilled. When they weren’t, when they—“You captured a Horde soldier? This was not what we agreed to, Commander!” No punishments followed. Or nothing more severe than threatening to take Catra out of the fight for a week. That would’ve been a reward back in the Horde.

Catra rolled her eyes.

“Lonnie’s an old ally of Adora’s. Since she split too it just took some… intense convincing to get her to tell us where Entrapta was. You just need to keep an eye on her until we get back with Entrapta.”

“And where is Entrapta?”

“Some island,” Catra shrugged. “It’s their version of exile and since they think no one knows where it is it’s not very secure. We’ll be in and out.”

“I assume you're going to Seaworthy first?” The queen sounded tired.

“Whoop whoop!” Bow cheered.

“Unless you want us to swim there,” Catra said.

“Be careful, would you,” the Queen said. “All of you,” her eyes pinned Adora down, giving her that threatening look she’d given her after learning the truth. She thought Adora was gonna put them at risk—she was probably right. But Adora was strong now. She could protect them.

“Yeah sure fine, whatever Mom, we’ll be careful,” Glimmer said. “Love you!”

“See you soon,” Catra said.

“I love—”

Catra turned off the tracker and passed it to Bow. “You ready to see your favorite sea captain, Bow?” She smirked.

“Are you ready to go back on a boat, Catra?” He grinned back, and Catra’s smirk fell off.

She turned back to Adora, “Are you sure it’s an island?” Adora nodded, and Catra sighed.

“I hate it here.”

“Well if it isn’t my old friends, the princesses of Bright Moon and master archer Bow!” A man called out from a back booth. Bow blushed and Adora glanced at him, eyebrows furrowed. Glimmer was steaming, and Catra was smirking. “Next rounds on them, barkeep!”

“Sea Hawk,” Catra greeted, leading the way to the booth. “Always a pleasure.”

Glimmer reluctantly pawned off some of their coin, and the barkeep passed them all tankards. Adora stared at hers and Catra took a gulp from Adora’s, having already finished her own.

“I assume you’re here because you’ve got another hair-raising ADVENTURE for me!” Sea Hawk puffed out his chest, raising his fist in the air and obviously flexing his bicep. Bow looked like he was about to keel over.

“Simmer down, Sea Man,” Catra muttered around her beer.

“It’s Sea Hawk,” Sea Hawk settled anyway, frowning. “Are you requiring a ship to see my dearest Princess Mermista again?”

“Do you know Beast Island?” Adora asked.

Sea Hawk’s eyes went wide, taking in Adora for the first time, “And who are you, my pirate friend? I don’t recognize you from any ships!”

“Oh I’m—I’m not a pirate,” Adora turned her head so the scar would be less visible.

“Nah, Adora’s closer to a knight,” Catra said, her fingers interlocked with Adora’s and Adora decided she was probably gonna die.

“I wanna be a pirate!” Bow cut in.

“If we could focus,” Glimmer said, loudly. “Can you take us there, or not?”

“Beast Island?” Sea Hawk tapped his chin. “The Horde prison? No one even knows where it is!” Someone began to play a piano and Sea Hawk’s eyes lit up as he took a deep breath, an accordion appearing from thin air. His voice took on a musical quality, “They say the island is infested with razor sharp—”

“We know where it is,” Catra cut in, rolling her eyes, the piano cutting off. Sea Hawk wilted.

“We need an experienced boat captain capable of handling treacherous waters and a quick escape,” Glimmer added.

“It’s going to be a bigger adventure than our voyage to Salineas,” Bow cut in. Catra had mentioned that they once attempted to get the princess of Salineas to join them. From the way she said it, Adora decided she probably didn’t want to know more.

“Which is why you won’t set anything on fire,” Catra said, slowly.

Sea Hawk grinned, “I make no promises!”

The Dragon’s Daughter was not a gigantic skiff, but it had a hold, two sails, and a set of ropes Bow was already working with.

“Ever been on a boat, my pirate friend?” Sea Hawk tossed Adora an eyepatch and she stared at it.

“Um, yeah. A few times.”

“You don’t have to wear that if you don’t want to,” Catra told her. “If anyone needs me I’ll be in the hold pretending I don’t exist.”

“Have fun, your highness!”

“Adora’s in charge!” Catra slammed the door shut behind her and Adora felt everyone’s eyes turn on her. “Uh—haha—I—um—”

“Onward to adventure!” Sea Hawk pointed at the horizon and Adora’s eye twitched.

“We’re going southwest.”

Sea Hawk rotated, “Onward to adventure!”

“Shut the fuck up!” Catra called, muffled by the door.

Adora looked at Glimmer. “Is he always like this?”

“Yes.”

“Isn’t he dreamy?” Bow sighed and Glimmer’s jaw clenched.

Adora looked between the three of them. Were they—nope. Adora had literally no idea. Catra would explain it later.

They untied the boat and got her sailing, Glimmer at the watch, Adora steering, Bow back to tying knots, and Sea Hawk at the rigging and bouncing around with an eyeglass. The eyepatch was

still in Adora's pocket, and if she was being honest, she really couldn't stop thinking about it.

Adora felt the wind cooling her back, was able to stretch out her leg, and closed her eyes against the salty spray. It was—peaceful? Adora had been fighting her entire life for peace but maybe she'd been going about it all wrong.

"Didn't I teach you better than to hide?" A voice asked. Adora kept her eyes closed—the voice was way too familiar. "You've betrayed every single person you've ever cared about. How long before you hurt one of them?"

Adora snapped her eyes open, focusing on the current, the horizon. "I couldn't."

"Or more likely, how long before they hurt you? It's survival of the fittest, you know that. Once Catra sees Entrapta's body she'll realize the truth. She'll kill you before you can hurt her precious baby sister."

"No. She wouldn't."

"No?" The voice asked. "You know she'll always put Glimmer above you. Or else what was that whole conversation about earlier?"

"That's not—"

"Be reasonable, Adora," the voice crooned. "We both know you know better."

Adora wilted, allowing the sea spray to drip down her cheeks.

Once, Adora had asked Catra what she'd do if she won the war. Adora had still been part of the Horde at the time and figured Catra would say something like burn the Fright Zone to the ground. Or maybe make sure every Horde soldier got the chair. She even thought Catra would say something frivolous, like build herself another ornate palace.

Catra had only started to exist in Adora’s head in that moment, when Catra told Adora that she wanted to see the world. A future had only started to exist in Adora’s head in that moment. A future where she and Catra could wander forever, could have no obligations, could relax.

Being with Catra felt like that, like a glimpse into her future, like endless opportunity, like anything could happen. Like a big vacation.

And vacations had to end.

Chapter End Notes

i Finally get to set up the plot i originally wrote this story for. the bfs but ON A BOAT

get ready for some good times fun party zone with the best friend squad but in the middle of the ocean headed towards certain doom all too aware of their own mortality!

a lot of y'all have been sending me asks. good. i have like 8 unopened asks. i feel like scrawnycatra never opening asks and endlessly powerful. i'll open them all though i promise. please don't stop sending them. my tumblr is @womenlovingwonderwoman

and you can find all the asks that i've finished answering under the tag bid my mother

huge thanks to @iamascret for helping me edit. you can find her work HERE where she is writing a soulmates au and a pacific rim au. both would highly recommend considering i beta both. Here's the pacfic rim au but i'm too lazy to link the other

i actually think i have a couple scenes written for this next chapter so it should be up soon! the more you comment the faster i type (500 words per comment buddy!)

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Sea Hawk has a good day.

Chapter Notes

this chapter is emotional and you might get really anxious so all I ask is that you stick with me and trust me and if you feel like giving up at least get to the end of the chapter

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sun set slower over the water than it did on land, Adora decided. Or maybe the whole world was moving slower. Whatever the reason, they still weren't at Beast Island.

Logically she knew that because of the laws of friction, a ship would of course be slower than a skiff. Water would slow down anything more than air. Also skiffs were all equipped with V8 twin-turbo engines that didn't run on wind power. But she'd thought—

"You alright there, Adora?" Bow asked.

"What?" She blinked up from her pacing. "Oh yeah. Fine. Just—thinking."

"I'm sure Entrapta will be fine," Bow said. He put a hand on her shoulder, drawing her up short. "And you know we're behind you one hundred percent."

"Yep," Glimmer poofed over, "we got your back!"

"A pirate never leaves a sister behind!" Sea Hawk proclaimed, jumping onto a chair and flexing his biceps. "Ooooh—"

The door to the hold slammed open and everyone jumped, Sea Hawk's shanty cutting off.

“No singing,” Catra growled at him and stalked over. “I’m not throwing up right now. Explain.”

“Maybe you’ve finally got your sea legs!” Sea Hawk said.

The blood drained out of Adora’s face as she looked over still waters, “We’re—we’re in the Doldrums.”

“The what now,” Catra asked.

“The Doldrums.” Adora turned to look at her. “When tropical storms meet at the equator, the rush of hot air—”

“We’re stuck,” Sea Hawk’s biceps wilted, getting smaller and smaller as he stepped off the chair, his voice picking up speed. “for who knows how long. Days, weeks, months, years—”

“Sea Hawk.” Catra grabbed him by the front of his shirt. “What do you mean we’re stuck in the middle of the ocean?”

“Do you have to be this dramatic?” Glimmer crossed her arms. “We are not getting stuck for weeks out here. We still have the tracker, we’ll just call Mom.”

“And we have She-Ra,” Adora pointed out. “I could paddle us out of here no problem.”

Catra glanced over the two of them, “We are not calling Mom, and you,” she glared at Adora, “are not turning into She-Ra to paddle a boat. We’ll figure something else out.”

Bow nodded. “We can at least give it a day. See if the wind picks up. There’s nothing we can’t do if we do it toge—”

“I’m going to the hold,” Glimmer announced, stomping away.

“Well the sun has set, and you know what that means,” Sea Hawk pulled out a bottle from his vest and Adora’s eyes widened.

“Contraband!”

Sea Hawk blinked at her. “It’s… booze.” He looked at the bottle. “Oh what do you know, the brand is actually Contraband.”

“Let me see that.” Catra snatched it from him. “‘Contraband Rum. For pirates and inmates alike.’” She took a swig. “That’s disgusting.” She took another swig.

“Hey! Sharing is caring!” Bow grabbed at it, and Adora backed away.

“I think—um—I think I’m gonna hang with Glimmer in the hold.”

“You don’t want to stay up here and drink with us?” Bow asked. “It’s a lot of fun, I promise.”

“Nah,” *absolutely not* , “I should um—make sure the maps are all right and stuff.” She nodded to herself and walked away.

They kept talking but even once she closed the door to the hold she could still hear their muffled chatter.

“God, she’s always having a breakdown,” Catra was saying.

“She is kinda high maintenance,” Bow responded.

Adora cringed, turning quickly away from the door. Glimmer was using the tracker, swinging back and forth on the hammock.

“Oh! Adora!” Glimmer’s eyes widened, turning off the tracker. “Um, I was just—um,” she slumped. “Talking to my mom.”

“Oh,” Adora blinked, taking a seat on the hammock across from her. Hopefully Catra wouldn’t mind sharing, at least for the voyage, since there were only four hammocks. Maybe it’d be better if Bow and Glimmer shared. “Um, why?”

Glimmer sighed. “She’s been all sad lately because of this fight with Catra.”

Adora winced: the fight that started because Catra had lied to the Queen to protect Adora. Since she got here she'd been the one being protected, not the other way around. If she was gonna save Etheria she had to stop being so weak.

"Oh yeah, I bet Catra's been talking to you about it," Glimmer nodded at her. "It's—really complicated, you know?"

Adora shrugged; she didn't see what was so complicated. Catra had lied to her mother, her mother was angry with her, her mother hated Adora, and now Adora's existence had put a rift between the two of them and ruined everything.

"I wish my dad were around," Glimmer picked at the hammock's cloth. "They used to get in fights when Catra was little and he always fixed it. But she's mad at him, too."

Adora blinked, "Um—why?"

Glimmer threw up her hands, "Right? It's so stupid! I'd say she's just ungrateful but that doesn't explain why she's so overprotective and annoying."

"Catra's not annoying."

Glimmer gave her a dirty look.

"…most of the time," Adora admitted.

"I just—I don't get how she can always be so mad at my mom. I know she's not perfect but… she tries her best."

Adora felt really really unqualified right now. "It's tough," she tried. "Um, moms and stuff, it's all tough."

"Yeah," Glimmer looked down, letting her legs swing. "Do you—um—you don't have to talk about it if you don't want but—do you miss Shadow Weaver?"

Adora stiffened, looking away. She had never quite forgotten that Glimmer and Bow were eavesdropping when Catra realized who had taken Adora's eye. They had never brought it up before, but Glimmer was probably tired of waiting for her to get over it.

"Sorry! We can talk about something else or—"

"All the time." Adora's voice was a lot smaller than she thought it'd be. "But sometimes I feel like she's still around. Just waiting."

"Well, she can't get you now," Glimmer put a hand on her shoulder. "Pirate code." She grinned and Adora smiled. "You are gonna try on the eye patch right?"

Adora rolled her eyes. "Maybe later."

A few hours passed like that, talking, Glimmer doing a lot of complaining. Whenever Adora hung out with Bow and Glimmer as a unit she always felt like a third wheel. And when Catra was there, the tension took up the whole room. She and Bow spent lots of time together, but this was really the first chance she'd got to hang out with Glimmer.

From all of Catra's complaining she kinda thought Glimmer was a prissy whiney snobbish princess. But already Adora could tell that Glimmer was ruthless, which honestly reminded her a lot of Catra. Or at the least, Adora could tell they were siblings.

Eventually it began to get late, and on Glimmer's third yawn Adora glanced over at the door.

"Where are they?" Glimmer asked.

"Sea Hawk brought Contraband," Adora told her.

Glimmer's smile faded. "They were drinking without me? Us, I mean. I mean they were drinking without us?"

"I don't drink." Adora squeezed her hands together.

“Put on your eyepatch, let’s go steal some alcohol like real pirates! ADVENTURE!” Glimmer stood up, brandishing an imaginary sword. Adora handed her the sword. “ADVENTURE!” Glimmer repeated.

“Wow,” Adora said, sliding on her eye patch. “Fortunately I think the royal guard up there will be helpless against you.”

Glimmer grinned at Adora putting on the patch. “Wow, that’s a total lewk. Bow and everyone are going to flip.”

“What? I was kidding, no way,” Adora scrambled to take it off, but Glimmer grabbed her arm and pulled her out of the hold.

“Guys—” She was interrupted by a huge uproar of laughter.

Catra’s speech was slurred. “You need to move on from—Mermista, man. She is sooooo not into you.”

“Not true! One—one time she said she liked my, uh, personal!” Sea Hawk argued, sounding like he was about to fall off the top of the ship where the three of them were perched.

“Your personal?” Bow asked.

“A word similar to that!” Sea Hawk corrected. “And if my relationship is so doomed where is your girlfriend right now?”

Adora took off the eyepatch, stuffing it in her pocket. This was so so stupid. Everything was stupid. She wasn’t good enough for Catra, that was the reality.

“Adora and I are—um—compli—compli—compli’ated. I guess. She’s been—she’s been through a lot. And I’m goin’ through a lot. I dunno.”

“Adora just didn’ wanna drink,” Bow pointed out, easily the most sober of the three, to no one’s surprise. “Now I know you’re drunk, if you think that’s a big deal.”

"It's not a big deal! I'm just saying—ugh. Whatever, Arrow Boy. At least I have the stones to actually be with the person I like. You haven't even asked 'em out yet."

"I'm just saying, it's kinda telling that Adora and I have spent whole days together and you guys only hang out when one of you is having a mental breakdown."

One of them being Adora, pretty much always.

"That's not true!"

"Isn't it? I get that you and Glimmer are like… fighting. But she and Adora are friends now and you can't avoid Glimmer without avoiding Adora."

"Well, Adora doesn't have to hang out with her."

"Maybe you should set a ship on fire to show her you care!" Sea Hawk cut in. "Or write her a shanty."

"Oh my god, Sea Hawk," Catra groaned. "Do you ever shut up?"

"Only when I'm drinking!" There was a thunking sound. "Ow."

Glimmer pulled Adora back into the hold. "Did you hear that?" Glimmer demanded. "Bow likes someone! Who do you think it is? Do you think it's Sea Hawk?"

"Um—"

"Oh my god, I bet it's Sea Hawk. He has a mustache and is an actual pirate, Bow has always loved pirates, I wouldn't be surprised if Bow left the rebellion forever to join his pirate crew and then he would get to wear your eyepatch and—"

"Glimmer, relax." Adora couldn't believe she was telling someone else to relax. Was this improvement? "I'm sure he's not gonna leave the rebellion. He lied to his dads for like years to join the rebellion, right? Why would he give that up now?"

Glimmer exhaled, letting her shoulders slump and nodded. “Yeah, yeah. He wouldn’t—he wouldn’t leave me for Sea Hawk. We’re best friends. He wouldn’t.” She took a deep breath and Adora nodded. She was good at this protecting Glimmer thing, screw her own brain. Catra was gonna be so impressed.

“I’m gonna go keep watch, because they’re definitely not going to,” Adora said.

Glimmer pulled out her tracker. “I’m gonna go snitch on Catra.”

Adora’s eye twitched, but she left before she could be implicated further. It was gonna be a long voyage.

The still waters of the Doldrums were not as calming as violence of the open ocean. But still, out here, the sky hanging above her and not on top of her, it was as close to peace as she felt like she could ever get. Maybe when Catra went traveling after the war she’d take Adora with her, maybe they’d even spend time on the water despite Catra hating it.

“Well at least Mermista doesn’t talk to herself.” Catra’s voice rang out clear from the hold, significantly more sober. Adora snuck closer. “I catch Adora doing it all the time. At this point I’m too afraid to break up with her because I think she’d wig out. I mean, that’s crazy right? Like she’s had fully-fledged conversations with herself. She has got to be crazy.”

“I’m not crazy!” Adora burst through the door. The hold was darker than it should’ve been and Glimmer was sleeping—no, too still to be sleeping—Glimmer was unconscious. “Glimmer!”

She ran over, Glimmer’s pulse thready and racing, her breaths coming out staggered. “No, no, no, Glimmer, wake up! It’s not real! Glimmer!”

“Adora!”

Adora turned. Catra stood silhouetted in the doorway. “Catra!”

“You hurt her!”

Adora’s gut turned to ice, “No, no I swear, I—”

“Catra no,” Sea Hawk grabbed her before she could leap.

“Adora, come on!” Bow appeared from the door. “Time to go!”

“I’ll kill you!” Catra screamed.

“No, I didn’t hurt her, you don’t understand! I didn’t—”

“Adora!”

The call was from across the ship, it sounded like Catra. The Catra in front of her vanished and Adora’s breath caught in her throat.

“No,” the word came out a whisper, and she grabbed Glimmer, slinging her across her shoulder and barreling through the ship. “Catra, I’m coming! Get everyone on the lifeboat!”

“Adora, I can’t see you! Can you see me?” Catra’s voice came out choked and Adora froze.

She was on a boat, stuck in the doldrums, wasn’t she? But shouldn’t they have been far from the equator? She felt in her pocket and the eye patch was gone. Was Sea Hawk real? Glimmer disappeared from her arms and Adora stumbled back against a—a stone wall? What—what was happening?

She pulled out her sword, the blade clumsy in her hands like she’d never held it before. Hadn’t she?

“Adora,” The voice crooned and Adora felt sweat drip down her back.

“Shadow—Shadow Weaver?” She cursed her weak voice and her weak body, and the darkness engulfing the room, boat, house, prison, wherever she was.

“Adora, there you are, my dear.” Shadow Weaver became a single being, the shadows growing larger as she loomed over Adora, blocking out the moons and casting a shadow over Adora’s face. “I was worried.”

Adora swallowed, she knew she was breathing too fast, she knew her heart was beating too fast—was she getting smaller or was the prison she was in getting larger? She had to—she had to do something—she promised. Her hands balled into fists at her sides, clumsy and young.

“Leave my friends alone!”

Shadow Weaver didn’t blink, only loomed closer, “What friends, Force Captain? Surely you remember I’m the only one you can trust, the only one who cares about you.”

“That’s not true!”

Catra was real, wasn’t she?

“She would drop you the instant her sister was in danger,” Shadow Weaver snarled, reading her thoughts the way she always could. There were never any secrets from her.

But she gave the game away. Catra was real.

“Let her go, Shadow Weaver,” Adora said, she raised the sword. “For the Honor of—”

The shadows snatched the sword, launching it into the ocean.

“NO!” Adora ran to the railing, but a wall of shadows blocked her view.

“Catra doesn’t care about you,” Shadow Weaver said from behind her. “She wants to use you for your strength.” She felt that cold hand of shadows on her shoulder and she whipped around, stumbling back to put distance between them, but Shadow Weaver only slid forward, advancing on her like a predator.

“I was a rebel too, once. They feared me and my power, as they fear you. They’ll never accept you, Adora. But I do.” Shadow Weaver’s voice turned kind and Adora almost wanted to put her hands over her ears, curl up into a ball and sob.

“You’re—you’re wrong.”

“You know deep down what I say is true,” Shadow Weaver’s voice rang out, high and clear over the ship and the waters. “You are every bit the cutthroat and ruthless force captain I raised you to be.”

Adora felt something in her crack and her leg gave out, glowing a deep sharp red along the scars Shadow Weaver had cut into her. The pain drowned out everything except Shadow Weaver’s voice, and the deep glow of her eyes.

“We can still take down Hordak. We can rule Etheria, together.” Shadow Weaver put a hand on her cheek, like she had countless times before, and touched their foreheads together. “Return to the Fright Zone, Adora. Come home to me.”

“I—I,” her voice was choked and she shut her eyes, trying to summon any courage, any confidence, anything.

“ADORA!”

Her eyes widened just in time to see the silver glint of her sword flying at her. She grabbed the handle, easily, like it was a magnet, and the blade glowed bright.

“No!”

Shadows focused on the water where the throw had come and Adora felt a hand on her elbow.

“Time to go.” Glimmer poofed her away and Adora staggered, feeling Catra’s hands on her arms steadying her. Catra was soaked to the bone.

“Sea Hawk,” Catra called.

“On it!” She watched him take the bottle of rum, now closed with a small piece of fabric, and light a match. He launched it at the ship and the whole thing was set ablaze.

Distantly, Adora could hear Shadow Weaver screaming.

She turned away, head in her hands, feeling Catra’s fingers card through her hair.

“It’s okay,” Catra whispered, “We’re safe.”

She didn’t feel safe.

The lifeboat was not a comfortable place to sleep, but thankfully no one complained.

Apparently, Catra had heard Adora’s screams and gotten Bow and Sea Hawk on the lifeboat; she had stayed behind to find Glimmer and Adora and had navigated through the shadows with her night vision.

It would’ve been a more exploitable weakness, Catra had muttered, if Shadow Weaver hadn’t fooled her multiple times with a fake Glimmer.

The real Glimmer had been unconscious in the hold and from the look Glimmer was giving Adora now, Adora could guess what that meant.

But it had been Catra who got the sword, the only one able to see well enough in the dark waters to grab it. She threw it at Shadow Weaver and—“You know the rest,” Catra finished. “I figure she’ll be too weak to try anything again at least for awhile, and then we’ll have my mom who can stop her.”

“Too bad we left behind the tracker,” Glimmer muttered. “And the maps.”

“And all the food,” Bow said.

“And the rum,” Sea Hawk finished.

“But,” Bow perked up, “we’re out of the doldrums.”

The sea was back to its normal turbulent self and Adora let her fingers run through it, almost a caress. Shadow Weaver had power over water, somehow. She’d have to talk to Catra and figure that out later.

“We should be at Beast Island in no time!” Bow pulled out an arrow and clicked a button, a compass popping out of it.

“Seriously?” Catra asked. He grinned.

“I can paddle us there,” Adora said, her voice small. “This was all my fault. Shadow Weaver wouldn’t have come if it weren’t for me. I put you all in danger, so let me get you out.”

“We’re in the middle of a war,” Catra reminded her. “We’re always in danger.”

“This is Shadow Weaver’s fault, not yours,” Glimmer added.

“No pirates left behind,” Sea Hawk said. “Oh and I found this, I think it must’ve fallen out of your pocket.” He held out his hand, revealing her eyepatch.

Catra let out a cackle, Glimmer and Bow laughed, and even Adora had to roll her eyes and smile. She took the eye patch and stuffed it back in her pocket, leaning against the side of the lifeboat. Catra scooted closer and rested her head on her shoulder, like it was nothing, like it was fine.

Adora closed her eyes, enjoyed the sensation.

Her leg ached.

Chapter End Notes

ill make the next chapter a little lighter and more comfort than hurt to make up for it all. but! I hope you enjoyed regardless!

now some important pieces of info!

first of all, i don't know if y'all knew this but we actually have fanart. you can go to @izanogi or click HERE to see the art of chapter 2 and HERE to see the art of chapter 3 book 1

i also have been answering asks and doing some in universe writing for this series on my blog @womenlovingwonderwoman so please send asks there and to find old stuff go to the tag bid my mother

and of course a huge thank you to @iamascret for editing. You can find her writing at iamascret, including the piece i'm editing total synergistics and A Dangerous Partnership, which i have to finish looking over lol. shit. hope she don't see this.

1 comment=500 words, do what you gotta do.

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

The squad gets some time to relax and, predictably, does not know what to do with it

Chapter Notes

thought i'd give y'all a break so this a quick chapter of mostly fluff

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There was a crick in Adora's neck the next morning, but Catra was still comfortable, her ear pressed against Adora's chest. Her hair was scratchy in the sea breeze but at least she wasn't seasick anymore, she even looked—peaceful?

"It's still dark out," Catra muttered, nuzzling closer.

Adora moved to accommodate her before she realized a rather crucial piece of information.

"Catra," she whispered, glancing around the lifeboat.

Sea Hawk was sleeping sprawled out on a bench, a bandana covering his face, while Bow and Glimmer were curled into one another, heads leaning against each other.

"What?" Catra whispered back.

"I can't feel my leg."

Catra blinked her eyes open, pressing a hand to it. "I can."

"Catra."

"Right." Catra shook her head, rubbing her eyes. "Good can't feel it or bad can't feel it."

“Is there a good can’t feel it?”

“Try standing.”

Adora nodded, putting a hand on Catra’s shoulder more firmly and propelled herself off with one leg to stand on the other. She nearly collapsed forward, but Catra caught her and pulled her back.

“Catra—”

“Hey, hey, it’s alright, you’re okay—” Adora willed herself to go still, her breathing to steady, imagining a cold wind blowing through her mind, freezing everything in motion, “—there you go, okay.”

“Okay,” Adora muttered back.

“It’s a leg, Entrapta will build you a new one. Or Bow will. I’ve even seen my mom do weirder stuff with her magic,” Catra said. “Or it’ll get better on its own. Who knows. You’re okay.”

“I—I—”

It was just one more thing wasn’t it? First she someone had to cover her side because she was fucking blind, Catra usually had to stick around her if she wanted to get through the night, they all just had to rescue her after she got them stranded, and now she couldn’t even walk. She was worse than useless, she’d get them all killed, she was nothing without Shadow Weaver, she was—

“Adora,” Catra’s hands were on her cheeks, forcing her to meet her mismatched eyes. “We’ll figure it out, but you’ve gotta talk to me. You promised.”

A gentle hand swiped away at her cheek. Oh god Adora was crying, she hadn’t done that since she was a kid. What the fuck.

“I *left* her, Catra,” Adora whispered, she closed her eyes and leaned into the hand on her blind side. It pulled her in, the other

looping around her back, supporting her. “I couldn’t stop her, I couldn’t protect you—you all.”

“Adora,” the name came out cracked, and Adora pressed closer, closer. Catra was so warm. “I—I heard some of the things she said. It’s all lies, you know.”

Adora shut her eyes, Catra didn’t know her, didn’t know the things she’d done, not like Shadow Weaver did.

“You’re not—you’re not ruthless or cutthroat and—you get to decide if you are or not. Not her. You’re in charge now, Adora.”

Adora curled her fingers in the cloth of Catra’s shirt, trying to go back to that same cold place. Her tears had frozen, but she was still breathing like she had just run a marathon in the Northern Reach and only Catra’s steady hand on her back was keeping her moving.

“I—um—I care a lot about you,” Catra’s voice came out stuttered now and Adora wondered if maybe she was being too needy. “You’re—you’re probably the best thing that’s ever happened to me. Or whatever. I mean—it’s going to be okay. I got you, and you got me. That’s what we said.”

Her breathing steadied, her thoughts felt slower, number, colder, and her entire body felt exhausted, but she lay her head against Catra’s shoulder, letting her hands relax against her shirt.

“Say something back or I’ll throw you overboard,” Catra whispered.

And something warm slipped out before she could stop it and, “You’re my favorite person.”

“Okay that is such bullshit, you know like five decent people. And only four of them are on this boat.”

Adora, in spite of herself, smiled, leaning into Catra’s hand at her back rubbing gentle circles. Catra never touched her back, usually

preferred her hands, her arms, her shoulders, her neck, would even place a hand on her thigh.

A thumb swept over one of the ridges on Adora's back and then again, and again, "What's that?" Catra asked and Adora remembered why she never let Catra touch her back.

"Um—it's not just my um leg. And face. And arms." Adora squeezed her eyes shut.

"It's on both your arms?" Catra asked.

"Less on the left."

"Okay. Do they—do they ever hurt too? The scars not on your leg?"

Adora moved closer, hoping that she could pretend the sea had drowned out the question.

"Adora, you promised."

"Sometimes," Adora grumbled. "But not as much. I think it's 'cause I use my leg more."

"More than your back and your face?" Catra asked, already annoyed.

"Differently then. Whatever."

"Adora," Catra's voice went soft again, "I'm just—I'm just trying to understand."

"I'm fine," Adora muttered.

Catra swallowed, "Well, I'm not."

Adora pulled away and looked at her, Catra didn't meet her eyes.

"Do you now realize how terrifying that was last night? I barely know how to swim and I was drunk off my ass, and you—you

were so scared. I've never—you always pretend to be fine around me. And I know you're not but—but seeing you like that—I was scared too. I was terrified and—" Catra looked at her hands and Adora followed her eyes, watching as her hands clenched into fists. "The only reason I didn't get back on that ship was because Glimmer beat me to it," she said finally, meeting Adora's eyes. "And I regret it, I should've kicked her ass when I had the chance."

Adora shook her head, "You—when she's like that there's no way to fight her. She's not even really there. Her body is in the Fright Zone."

Catra hummed, looking thoughtful. "We'll figure it out later. Maybe Entrapta will know something."

"If she's alive," Adora pointed out, and Catra nodded.

"Yeah."

They didn't talk much after that. Eventually the shine of the eighth moon woke up the other three and Catra was careful to avoid making Adora stand. She managed to transform the Sword of Destiny into a paddle without getting up, and they slowly made their way forward. Bow's compass was a decent one, and with the moons acting as navigators they at least knew they weren't going the wrong way.

Still, Adora's arms got tired fast, and with one leg she wasn't using all her power. She knew that. Catra knew that. It felt like everyone was staring at her waiting for her to break—but she wouldn't.

"So we should make a plan," Glimmer said at last. "We have to face the facts. We're stuck in the middle of the ocean with no food, and no water, and no way to call for help."

"I say we eat Sea Hawk first," Catra said.

Glimmer scowled at her and Sea Hawk leaped behind Bow.

“I’ll fish for us,” Adora took her sword out of the water and transformed it from a paddle to a fishing line.

“Don’t you need bait for that, Adora?” Bow asked.

Adora sighed and transformed it back into the paddle, resuming the work.

“We know we’re going in the right direction but we don’t know how far away we are,” Glimmer continued.

“Can’t be that far,” Catra said.

“What makes you say that? Who knows how far those doldrums drifted us, we could even be—”

Catra twirled a seagull feather between her fingers, plucked straight from the ocean. “A day out. Probably.”

“Okay, so we get to Beast Island,” Glimmer crossed her arms. “We magically rescue Entrapta and then we paddle back to Seaworthy? With, again, no food and no water.”

“There might be food and water on the island,” Bow said.

“I will arrange for help to come!” Sea Hawk stood, chest puffed out. “For my darling Princess Mermista has taught me how to converse with the seabirds! We will be rescued in no time!”

When Sea Hawk did finally manage to flag down a seagull he let out a long series of squawks, her neck bending in a bad direction as he tried to get the sound just right.

The bird shat on his head.

Catra’s eye twitched and Adora’s muscles tensed. Any other day Catra would’ve laughed long and hard, but now she just seemed pissed. This mission was Adora’s idea, Adora had promised the queen to keep everyone safe, she was letting her down.

“Why can’t you just teleport to Seaworthy, Sparkles?”

“Because, *Kit*, I have no idea where it is relative to where we are now. Plus, it’s days away and I probably would drown before I made it.”

“Oh no. That’d be awful.”

“Can’t we all just—”

“Well maybe if you weren’t such a—”

“Big words from a—”

“How about a shanty to pass the time?”

“No!” Glimmer and Catra yelled, agreeing for the first time all trip.

Adora flinched and focused on paddling, wishing someone else could take over. Her hands were gonna have calluses for days.

“Arguing isn’t helping,” Bow said. “We need to be working together.”

“Arguing about what? The plan is to sit tight.” Catra crossed her arms. “Glimmer’s just mad that, once again, she’s useless.”

“Glimmer,” Bow put a hand on her shoulder. He looked at everyone else. “I think we’re all just really tired and hungry and kind of hungover. Maybe it would be best if we just relaxed for awhile.”

“Do you want us to play the quiet game too, Mom?” Catra asked.

Adora shrunk into herself, wishing she could vanish.

“Catra,” even Bow sounded pissed off now. *Bow*. “Maybe *you* should play the quiet game.”

“Maybe you should—”

"*I once met a lass so fine*
She was drunk on Barley wine
I'd been to sea for months of three
I knew I could make her mine
And the lass was past consent
So it was off with her we went
And we threw her in bed and rested her head
And we left, 'cause that's what Gentlemen do," Sea Hawk quietly hummed to himself and Adora focused on that, tuning out the rapidly escalating argument.

"Adora!" Adora turned to look at Catra who looked positively livid, now standing to match Bow and Glimmer. "Tell them!"

"Oh please!" Glimmer had both her fists clenched, "You can't use her like that! Adora is her own person!"

"*A woman has a right to a drink or two*
Without worryin' about what you will do!
We say 'Yo, ho!' but we don't say 'ho,'
'Cause 'ho' is disrespectful, yo."

"I know that! You're the one who treats her like she can just turn into She-Ra," Catra spat back. "None of you would've given a shit about her if she wasn't a princess!"

"That's not true! We didn't even know she was when we met her!" Bow pointed out.

"Right, and how well did you treat her? You didn't begin to trust her until she found that stupid sword!"

"*There once was a girl from Leeds—*"

"Guys!" Adora got to her feet, gently rocking the boat as she stumbled on her bad leg, pins and needles shooting up her thigh.

Catra was instantly at her side, gripping her hand and easing her back down.

“Adora, what’s wrong?” Bow asked, his Glimmer’s eyes wide with concern now, and Sea Hawk stopped singing.

“Um—”

“It’s an old injury,” Catra said. “It’s been bothering her since Dryl.”

“I’m fine,” Adora cut in. “It’s just—it’s the sea air. I think.”

“You shouldn’t be paddling anymore,” Glimmer said.

“Yeah,” Catra agreed. “We might not be able to use the paddle without you but the current is taking us in the right direction, we can float.”

“Or Bow and I can get out and kick!” Sea Hawk puffed his chest out.

“You told me last night you couldn’t swim, Sea Hawk,” Catra glared.

Sea Hawk wilted. “Oh, yes. I keep forgetting about that.”

“Why would a sailor not know how to swim?” Adora asked. “Even Horde cadets had to be proficient by age nine and we didn’t even see the ocean until active combat.”

“It’s bad luck!” Sea Hawk told her, winking.

“You’ve set your own ship on fire 6 times,” Glimmer said.

“Avast thee! Land Ho!” Sea Hawk pointed at the horizon.

It wasn’t actually land, just a piece of driftwood. But by the witching hour the shore was in sight, the sun just beginning to set as their lifeboat hit soft, white sand.

“This is Beast Island?” Catra asked, digging her feet into it, supporting Adora as she limped onto solid ground.

Adora looked at the thick underbrush, the practical wall of jungle and winced, taking out her sword. “Yeah.”

“I can’t believe we made it,” Glimmer said.

“Should we wait until it’s light out?” Bow asked.

Adora shook her head. “It might already be too late for Entrapta. We need to go now.”

“But what about your leg?” Glimmer asked.

Adora transformed the sword into a cane, taking her weight off of Catra. “I’ll be fine. Entrapta’s been here for weeks.”

“We go now,” Catra said. “We’ll be fine. Glimmer and Bow will take up the rear, I’ll lead, Sea Hawk, you and Adora will take the sides. If everyone keeps their eyes peeled and we get her trail early we can be in and out by sunrise.”

Everyone looked at each other.

“And we’ll figure out how to get off the island later,” Catra rolled her eyes. “Now let’s go.”

Catra walked into the wood, and Adora, hobbling on her cane, followed.

Chapter End Notes

> lol when i said last chapter was rough i meant like... emotionally. and for the person who pointed out the plot holes yes :) that's where the light gets in :)
>
> jkjkjkjkj
>
> okay so actually important announcements PLEASE READ THIS!!!
>
> for those who aren't following me on tumblr (please do that my account is a @womenlovingwonderwoman)

you don't know im completely reorganizing the series. the one shot series i promised after bid my mother has instead become a two shot, completed (tho i might add a prequel of glimmer and catra meeting). the one shot series i promised will take a wee bit of a different form.

so after this work completes (we got about 1 more to go but it might be 2 chapters) I will add another work to this series, it will have three one shots (so far) on it.
- angella and adora hanging out pre the events of this work
- entrapta and adora hanging out pre the events of this series
- bow and adora hanging out post the events of this work
(if you want something else comment i'm very amenable, these have all been by request on my tumblr @womenlovingwonderwoman)

none of these will advance the plot and all of these won't have a beta. The following, however will advance the plot.

from there i will post a new work that will be either a one shot or a two shot. the first chapter will be from adora's perspective and the second, if it exists will be from glimmer's perspective.

after that I will post another work that will also be a one shot, this one from catra's pov and the last work of the series will be a multichap from catra's pov. that's the plan so far at least, though it's subject to change.

After i post that final work the series will be over and I'll post here sporadically if at all. I will not stop writing though I have a couple pieces in the works I think you'll love and i have a holiday story that will come out this month!

If you've never read an authors note before you probably don't know that iamascret
is a friend of mine who is always the second pair of eyes on this series and who I beta for on her works total synergistics (a catradora pacific rim au) and a dangerous partnership (a

catradora canon soulmate au).
We're writing a story together for the holiday season and it's sure to be toothing rottingly sweet and also weirdly angsty because neither of us have self control. She'll be doing the adora pov and I'll do the catra pov. Definitely subscribe to one of us though so you can get notifs about when it's posted.

last couple things!

please find me on tumblr at @womenlovingwonderwoman and send me asks! I've gotten a bunch of them so far and you can find that, other pieces of writing ive done for the series that i haven't posted here under the tag bid my mother

you can find iamascret at @iamascret and she also does catradora art.

speaking of catradora art! We have a fanartist! @izanogi has done some really beautiful art from chapter 3 HERE and some art from book 1 HERE

please check those out and don't forget to leave a comment! 1 comment = 500 words

thanks for reading and see you soon!

(jesus christ this is a fuckin newsletter, can you tell that's what my job was?)

(the first to tell me about the shanty (don't cheat now) gets an extra 50 words)

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

Welcome to Beast Island

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora felt the change as soon as she stepped into the wood, and it was so abrupt she nearly collapsed, Catra grabbing her hand at the last second.

"What's happened? Did it get worse?"

"No," Adora's eyes were wide, "It—I can't feel it."

"Can't feel your whole leg or—"

"No, no the pain. I don't—it doesn't hurt anymore. It's like it never happened." Adora put more weight on the leg, testing it, but it was brand new again. She almost wanted to check if the scars had disappeared too.

"Most of this stuff looks like old first one's junk," Bow looked around at the black towers, the flickering blue lights painting the forest in an eerie glow. "Since the wound is magical, and this technology has magic incorporated into it…?" He shook his head.

"Do you think there could be a cure?" Adora asked. "I could feel this way all the time?"

He shrugged.

"Uh, men?" Sea Hawk called. "This didn't happen to belong to anyone did it?" He held up a mask and Adora's heart constricted on herself.

"That's Entrapta's!" She ran over and snatched it from his hands.

Her fingers ran over the hairline cracks in the metal, some old, most very very new.

“We’re on the right track then,” Catra said.

One of the glasses over the eye holes was broken.

“She never goes anywhere without this,” Adora said.

“Hey,” a hand landed on Adora’s shoulder and she jumped. It was Glimmer, who offered her a smile. “We’ll find her.”

Adora looked at Catra, who wasn’t making eye contact.

“We should keep moving,” Adora said. “We’re a large group but that doesn’t mean there aren’t predators who’ll decide we’re easy pickings.”

“I’ve got a pack if you want me to carry that for you,” Bow said, holding out his hand for the mask. Adora held it close to her chest.

“It’s not heavy. It’ll be fine.”

They kept walking. Adora could lead the way now, her leg easily supporting her weight, without even a twinge, and Catra stuck by her blind side, occasionally cutting down a branch before it could wack Adora’s face. If there was a cure for her leg though maybe there was a cure for her eye. For the first time in a long time Adora wondered if maybe she wouldn’t have to be a burden on everyone around her forever. Maybe she could actually be strong again.

“Ow, fuck,” Catra stopped, putting her hands over her ears, “God what do you think that is?”

“What is?” Adora looked around, hand on her wrist, ready to draw the sword.

"That sound!" Catra glanced around, ears plastered to her head, "Seriously, no one hears it?"

Adora swallowed hard and Glimmer exchanged a look with her. "Is it—do you think it's Shadow Weaver?" Adora asked.

"It's a loud mechanical sound so I doubt it," Catra muttered. She straightened, "It—it faded. But no one heard it? Just me?" Adora nodded and Catra's shoulders bunched up, her tail curling around her leg. "Great. I love a spooky island filled with sounds only I can hear. Just great."

Adora put a hand on her shoulder, and desperately searched for something reassuring. In the end, they just kept walking.

Beast Island would not have been Adora's first choice for a… Bow had called it a hike. Right. Yeah, Beast Island wasn't exactly scenic, and the robot trees seemed to enjoy tripping Adora up. Catra took her hand when she tripped for the umpteenth time, and Adora would've felt that familiar sharp pain of guilt down her back like an anxious sweat, but Catra wasn't fairing much better

It seemed that every time Adora finished nearly falling over Catra would be hit by an invisible sound and be forced to stop, only kept from stumbling by Adora's steady hand. Catra kept saying it wasn't Shadow Weaver but it had to be. Shadow Weaver would stop at nothing and sooner or later Adora would need to face her. With the way Catra's face kept contorting, Adora was ready to swear up and down it'd be sooner.

"*There once was a girl from Leeds*
Who I heard was good on her knees
So I docked my ship for an overnight trip
To take care of all of my needs
She was fine as the tales did tell
And my mast began to swell
So I laid her down and raised her gown
And performed cunnilingus for an hour or so," Sea Hawk sang as

they walked, his cutlass drawn and rapidly swiping at vines that happened to brush him.

“Seriously, Sea Hawk?” Catra asked.

“Just wait until the chorus!” Sea Hawk stepped on a rock and raised his sword, putting the other hand to his chest.

“ *Always take care of yer lady fair—*”

“Boo you suck.”

“‘Cause they deserve as much attention down there!”

“Nobody is asking for this.”

“We say ‘Yo, ho!’ but we don't say ‘ho—’”

“I’m going to rip out your vocal chords.”

“' *Cause "ho" is disrespectful* , um… did anyone else notice how quiet it got?”

Sea Hawk put his foot down and Adora pulled out her sword.

“Fuck!” Catra slapped her hands to her ears and crumpled.

“Catra!”

Something roared and before Adora could think she was lifting Catra into her arms. “Bow and Sea Hawk cover us! Glimmer!” Glimmer looked at her, eyes wide with fear, “Get us out of here!”

“Right! Sorry!”

Glimmer grabbed Adora’s shoulder and with that same sickening swish they were somewhere else. Glimmer poofed away again and Catra groaned.

“Are you okay? What happened? Was it the noise?”

“I’m—where is everyone?” Catra pulled away from Adora’s arms and Adora had to fight to stop herself from reaching back out, pulling her back into safety.

“Glimmer got us out but—”

“You let her go back?” Catra demanded, “Why didn’t you just—” Her mouth shut and she rubbed her forehead.

“Why didn’t I just what?” Adora asked, voice soft.

“I’m—I—I didn’t mean that.”

“Mean what?” Something wasn’t matching up. Was she… talking about She-Ra? “How much of what happened on the ship was real, Catra?”

Catra looked stricken and any ease from before was gone. Adora felt cold all over and realized, like lightning down her spine, the truth.

"Shadow Weaver was right, wasn’t she? You just want to use me.”

“That’s not true,” Catra was shaking her head, reaching out but wind felt like it was rushing through her ears, everything muffled and distant.

“Isn’t it?” Adora stepped back, voice cracked. “It’s why you said when we met, that I had to fulfill my destiny. Do you even—am I even anything to you?”

“Adora—”

“I would’ve done anything and you—you knew that. You used me. That’s all I’m good for. All I’ll ever be good for—”

“Adora!” Catra tackled her and Adora blinked in surprise, vines growing up her feet. Catra slashed at them and instantly Adora started feeling warm again. “Are you okay?” Catra cradled her cheeks and Adora gripped one of her wrists, heart pounding.

"I—I—"

"You're everything, do you hear me? You're everything to me."

Adora couldn't think, could barely breathe, so she swung forward, and pressed their lips together and pressed forward, forward, so desperate for that softness, that warmth always escaping her, slipping through her fingers. Catra held her tight, like she was scared of the very same thing.

Adora knew, eventually, they'd have to actually talk. About what happened on the boat, about Glimmer, about what Catra wanted from Adora, but for now—together like this—it was hard to believe they weren't already on the same page.

There was a *poof* and they moved apart, Catra pulling Adora up as the four newcomers adjusted to their new orientation.

Wait. Glimmer, Bow, Sea Hawk and—

"Who's the schmuck?" Catra asked.

Adult male, above average stature and athletic build. Perhaps an inhabitant of the island, an old prisoner that somehow survived but never escaped. Most likely an ally, if Glimmer saved him, but if it came down to it—Adora could take him. She'd have to play it safe and keep a low profile to get the drop on him though.

"It was amazing!" Bow said. "He did some crazy magic and totally rescued us!"

The man kept his hood up, a staff in one hand. If he was able to take down the monster with his magic alone, it'd probably take She-Ra to beat him.

The man pulled off his hood, "I could've taken the beast myself if you hadn't teleported us. How did you do that?" He demanded, glaring at Glimmer. Everyone gasped and Adora put a hand on her forearm, ready to pull out the sword the second he moved against Glimmer.

“King Micah?” Bow asked, gaping at the man. No, King Micah was dead. The intel was that King Micah was dead, Queen Angella had told her King Micah was dead, everyone said King Micah was dead.

Bow and Sea Hawk bowed but Catra and Glimmer didn’t move.

“Oh please,” the man put up a hand, “your friends are right not to kneel,” he gestured at his daughters, “I’m no king here.”

Glimmer stepped forward, her eyes brimming with tears. “You don’t—you don’t recognize us?”

Catra’s expression was one of emotionless shock, her mouth open and eyes wide and blank, Adora grabbed her hand and it only hung loosely in her own.

Micah glanced at Glimmer, brow furrowing, and he looked again, deeper, and frowned. “You can’t be—that can’t be my little Glimmer, is it? You aren’t my babygirl, my little Glimmer, are you?”

Glimmer rushed into his arms and he looked like he’d been hit by a light canon, arms looping around her. He looked up and Catra stepped back, her eyes widening further, ears going back.

“Kit? Is that you, too?”

Catra swallowed hard, “Hey Dad. Long time no see.”

“Get in here.” He reached out a hand and Catra fell into him too, the two of them engulfed in his arms.

They didn’t move for a long time, and Adora gestured at Bow and Sea Hawk to cover their sides as beasts roared in the distance.

Eventually, Adora’s tapping foot got the better of her, and she couldn’t help but think of Entrapta, still alone.

She made eye contact with Bow who shook his head and then at Sea Hawk.

" *I once had a woman so fair —*"

"Sea Hawk, I'm going to skin you alive," Catra growled, and the three finally pulled away.

"So how—how old are you both now?" Micah looked at both of them, hands on both their shoulders, tears streaming easily down his cheeks. "I didn't think I could've been gone longer than a year or two."

"Try almost a decade and a half," Catra said.

"There's a lot we need to catch you up on." Glimmer took his hand. "These are our friends. Sea Hawk, Bow, and Adora."

"It's an honor to meet you, your Majesty!" Bow said, rushing forward arm outstretched. King Micah's eyes narrowed at Adora, staring at her scars and she stared back at his.

She wondered if he got them the same way Shadow Weaver did.

Micah finally noticed Bow and pinched his cheek. "Nice to meet you young man! Alive and real and definitely not a figment of my imagination living being!"

"Umm—"

"Dad!" Glimmer grabbed his arm and smiled sweetly. "What if you didn't grab my friend's faces?"

He released Bow who cowered behind Sea Hawk.

"Of course," Micah looked sheepish, "My apologies. I've been… alone. For awhile. What were you kids—how did you even know I was here?"

"We didn't," Adora said, when it was clear no one else wanted to say it. "We're looking for Princess Entrapta of Dryl. Have you seen her? Five foot three, long purple hair held in pigtails usually used as separate limbs—"

“Yes, yes, not too long ago, maybe a few days. Time is… hard here.” He looked at Catra and Glimmer again, eyes narrowed, “Clearly.” He looked back at Adora, “She was headed for the center of the island, said she wanted to follow the signal. I tried to warn her but—”

“Why? What’s the signal?” Catra asked.

“Have you heard it?” He asked her.

“Is it a loud mechanical sound?”

Micah grabbed her arm, paling, “That’s bad, that’s really bad. We need to get you out. Everything new here becomes part of the island eventually and it’s all to do with that signal. It convinces you it’s hopeless, that you’re nothing…” He kept talking but Adora couldn’t hear him.

Was that what happened with those vines? She hadn’t heard a signal though, how could it have happened to her?

Catra was looking at her now, god, was everyone? Were they all seeing how pathetic she was, that she didn’t even need to hear the signal to be absorbed into the island?

“We need to get Entrapta,” Bow said, and Adora blinked at him. “If she was headed towards the signal she’s probably in more danger than we thought.”

“She’s probably dead. You kids can’t go there.” Micah said, but he was only looking at Catra, “If you’re already hearing the signal—”

“I’ll teleport us in there and teleport us out,” Glimmer said, “It’ll be easy.”

“We can’t waste your teleports like that, Glimmer,” Bow said. “You’ve teleported like a bunch of people the last few days. How many do you even have left?”

“We don’t need teleports.” Sea Hawk lifted his sword, “I will go and face the beasts on my own and return with the lovely princess Entrapta. My dearest princess Mermista will be overcome with yearning and—”

“I haven’t heard the signal,” Adora pointed out. “And neither has Bow or Sea Hawk. Besides, Entrapta knows me. The three of us should go, you three should stay here where it’s safe.”

Catra’s eye twitched, and she let out a few chuckles. “Adora, if you really think I’m going to let you—”

“This is so stupid." Glimmer crossed her arms, “We all know we’re all gonna end up going.” She looked at everyone, “Dad, Catra isn’t going to listen to you. Bow, I’ll try and be careful. Sea Hawk, Entrapta will not want to be a part of that. Adora, none of us would do that if you paid us. And Catra, ugh. Since when am I the voice of reason?”

She glared around at everyone before Catra’s ear flicked. “The signal is a lot quieter now but if it’s from the center of the island I can take us there.”

Adora reached out to grab her hand but Catra shoved it in her pocket, with a warning glance at Adora. Adora did something wrong again, hadn’t she? Maybe the kiss—or—was she mad about what Adora had said? She must’ve known Adora didn’t mean that, right?

As Catra led them deeper into the woods Adora found herself lagging behind with Bow and Sea Hawk—who were actually not a bad pair. Adora almost hoped they would get together, like Glimmer thought they might. Maybe then Sea Hawk would stop moaning over Mermista all the time.

“Adora,” Bow put a hand on her shoulder. “I want to apologize about earlier.”

“Earlier?”

"I didn't know about your leg, I should've been more conscientious."

Adora blinked at him. "I was hiding it from you. From everyone."

"Pirates don't let pirates forget their peg-legs at the bar," Sea Hawk said. "Especially when they're too drunk to notice."

"I wasn't drunk."

Sea Hawk clutched the area of his shirt above his heart and closed his eyes, pausing in the middle of a deadly jungle. "Drunk on trauma," he said quietly.

Adora's eye twitched.

"Are you twinks coming or what?" Catra called.

"I'm more of an otter!" Sea Hawk responded, bounding to catch up with the group.

"I am *not* a twink," Bow muttered and followed.

"What's a—"

Bow's face contorted, "Ask any other question but that."

"So how's your mother? Your studies? Aren't you a little young to be in the Rebellion?" King Micah asked from the front of the group.

Catra began slashing through the underbrush a little more viciously than necessary and Glimmer's back straightened.

"Mom's good. Hasn't changed that much. She's missed you a lot, though. Our studies are good. We're pretty much finished at this point. And the only reason the rebellion has lasted this long is because Catra got promoted to Commander."

Glimmer looked expectantly at Catra who huffed and kept slashing.

“Catra?” King Micah asked.

Catra’s back straightened. “Adora, I need to talk to you about something. Right now.”

“Right now?”

“Right. Now.”

Catra grabbed her by the wrist and pulled her away from the group and Adora had to fight not to turn around and see their eyes on her. Her heart beat in her chest, and she had to steel herself.

They were stuck on an island, because of Adora, and not just any island but literally the most dangerous and terrifying one on the planet. Catra wouldn’t be able to bring her long lost father home to her mother and stupid Glimmer had brought it up and Catra was realizing it and realizing it was Adora’s fault and she was going to break up with her because Adora wasn’t worth everything she put—

“Oh thank god.” Catra sagged against her as they finally got out of ear shot, huddled behind a rock. Her hand slid from Adora’s wrist to her fingers as she interlocked their hands. “This is…” she trailed off, not even willing to finish the sentence.

“I’m sorry,” Adora offered, not even sure what she was apologizing for, just hoping it would help.

“I just—” Catra’s voice sounded choked now and Adora squeezed her hand, anxiety rushing through her as she glanced around.

“Hey, hey, it’s okay. We’ll figure it out.” She lowered her voice and tried to meet Catra’s eyes.

“Yeah,” Catra looked at her, and something about it was different, Adora could tell. She was looking at Adora differently than she ever had. “Yeah we will.”

Glimmer screamed.

Chapter End Notes

y'all thought this was the last chapter. so did i. but this baby got long so we're splitting it into two. It'll be up probably two weeks? maybe one? probably two. work is vv crazy rn. I have the angella and adora one shot written tho so lobby me about that and maybe i'll post it on tumblr @womenlovingwonderwoman or comment and maybe I'll post the one shot series before I finish this lol.

if i did post it on tumblr it would be under the bid my mother tag there.

Also! In case you didn't know because you're not following me on tumblr I have a holiday themed work out! It's called ghosts of Christmas and I'm cowriting it with iamascret

if you don't know who that is she helps edit this series and i beta her works total synergistics and a dangerous partnership so go read that shit.

also follow her on tumblr too at @iamascret. thanks queen for everything you do <3

and thanks to all of you for reading this!! the new chapter will be up soon but it comes sooner when you comment!!!! (one comment=500 words and one fan art=1000 words)

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

> The squad gets a second chance to rewrite the past, and predictably blow it.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“For the honor of Grayskull!” Adora shouted.

She opened her eyes, barely even feeling the healing power wash over her face as she ran towards the screams.

She stopped short when she realized she hadn’t felt it at all.

“What is it?” Catra asked, hand on her pommel. “Why can’t you transform?”

Something churned in her gut and she tried, searched for anything to say, even an apology but—

“Adora!” Catra dragged her by the wrist, pulling her away from the climbing vines. “We’ll save Glimmer and then talk, alright?”

Adora opened her mouth but Catra was already running, bursting towards the screams.

Bow and Sea Hawk burst through the shadow forest wall. “Other way!” Bow screamed, “Other way!”

“Where’s Glimmer, Arrow Bow?” Catra demanded.

“She’s with your father,” Sea Hawk said. “He told us to split up so we could get you.”

“We have to go,” Bow tried grabbing Catra by the arm but she shook him off, running back where he had come from.

Adora followed, raising her sword above her head again, “For the honor of Grayskull!” A flicker, maybe, nothing. “Why won’t you work?”

Creatures, maybe only tall enough to reach Adora’s waist, surrounded Glimmer and King Micah. Glimmer was struggling, her foot caught in a sea of vines that grew ever taller over her body. Micah stood in front of her, one hand drawing forth a spell, the other cast over Glimmer.

The creatures caught sight of Adora and Catra immediately and hissed, revealing layers of razor sharp teeth.

"Pooka!” Adora realized, remembering the stories. “They hunt in packs, surrounding their prey once it’s too late.”

“Catra? What are you doing here?” King Micah called. “Never mind that, it’s too late now, get your sister out of here. I’ll hold it off for as long as I can. Get to the center of the island, save Entrapta, and tell your mother—”

Adora blinked. She looked down at her hands and found them smaller, chubbier. She looked at Catra and her mane untamed, back as a child. Screams sounded from outside the Bright Moon palace, and King Micah looked scared.

“I love you, Kit.”

The First One’s temple had shown a vision of the two of them, together, as children. What if that wasn’t just a vision? What if they had grown up together? Would Catra still look at her the way she just had?

She looked back at King Micah, the only adult out of all of them left. He was an adult and he was doing this, to Catra, to Glimmer. But he wasn’t just doing this, he was doing it again.

Catra’s expression had set, like she was ready to just nod and agree.

Hadn’t anybody learned?

She blinked again and the world transformed back to Beast Island, to Micah with gray streaks in his hair, Catra with a commander’s pauldron, Glimmer with magic at her fingertips, and Adora—here late but here now.

“For the honor of Grayskull!” She plunged her sword in the dirt, thrown back as pure energy ripped from her muscles and surged over Glimmer, freeing her from the vines.

Catra’s hands caught her, Adora knew they would.

“Are you okay?”

Adora looked at her hands, expecting them to be small, or maybe scarred, but She-Ra was huge and bright and pure.

“I—yes.”

Catra gave her a nod.

“She-Ra,” King Micah whispered and she looked over at him. “You’re really back.”

“She-Ra later, monsters now!” Glimmer said, she grabbed a large stick, holding it like a club.

Catra unsheathed her claws and Adora lifted her sword.

“Stick together everyone, they’ll run if they decide we aren’t worth the effort,” Catra called.

“We need to get off this island,” King Micah called. “I’ve only made it this long because I didn’t draw attention to myself.”

Adora grit her teeth. “Glimmer, your majesty, just focus on hacking your way to us, once we’re together we can figure out a way to get to the shore. That’s where Bow and Sea Hawk would’ve gone too.”

Something pounded behind them and a shadow cast itself over Adora, she closed her eyes, "What now?"

The pooka ran off, as the beast opened its gaping maw. Adora held up her sword, felt Catra take her hand.

"'In and out,' I told my mom," Catra muttered. "She is not gonna be happy."

Two twin lights shown from inside the monster and then something perked up. "Hey guys! We got back up!" Bow jumped out from the mouth, Sea Hawk leaping like a ballerina.

"We have located the, um, unique princess—"

"Entrapta," Adora's voice was smaller, even smaller still as her body shrunk down into her normal form. "Is that you?"

The being inside the monster swung forward, into the light, and flicked up her almost bug-like mask. "Adora?"

Adora's knees gave out, relief hitting her in the stomach like a blunt object. "You're—you're okay. Oh thank god." She covered her face, trying to collect herself, couldn't. "I thought—they sent you to Beast Island and—"

"Oh! I love Beast Island! There's so much great tech here!" Entrapta hopped onto the ground. "What are you doing here?"

"Trying to save you!" Adora braced herself against Catra's hand and pulled herself up. Catra squeezed her hand.

"Oh," Entrapta frowned, "you weren't doing a great job."

"Hey!" Glimmer crossed her arms.

"Thanks for coming," Adora smiled, "Are you actually okay then? What happened?"

“We can catch up when we get to my lab! I’ve discovered so much about the planet!”

“Your lab?”

Entrapta hopped back in the beast. “Come on!”

They were cramped, to say the least. Even with Catra on her lap, Glimmer in Bow’s, and Sea Hawk in King Micah’s, Adora still smelled more of Bow’s armpit than she ever wanted to.

“Beast Island log, time cycle 37,” Entrapta rattled off, a beep in the robot indicating she was recording, “I have confirmed the outside world still exists! I found princesses! Well, two princesses, one magic and one non-magic like me! Then I also found Adora, and those three, I don’t know them.” She leaned over to Adora, “Do I know them?”

“You stole my food,” King Micah glared.

“Oh yeah!” Entrapta smiled. “It was delicious.” She looked back at Adora, “Something’s different. Didn’t you have two eyes?”

Adora looked down. “Uh yeah.”

“Back off,” Catra growled and Adora put a hand on her shoulder, before turning to face the music.

“Entrapta we’ve been looking all over this island for you. It’s my fault you got sent here, I’m so—”

“Oh don’t apologize! This place is paradise!”

She began jumping up and down in excitement and somehow landed on Bow’s face.

“What’s that?” Catra demanded.

“It’s an island full of technological monstrosities, each more deadly than the next! How could I not love it?”

“A woman after my own heart,” Sea Hawk declared. “Adventure calls to us like no other!”

“We came all this way to rescue you and you don’t even want to be rescued?” Glimmer asked.

“Oh but I’m glad you came, Adora! I found out some information that the Horde is gonna really find useful!” Entrapta frowned, “Should I not say it in front of the princesses?”

“Entrapta I’m—I defected. I’m with the princesses now.”

“Oh! Okay! Well can I still tell you about it?”

Adora blinked. “Um, of course.”

“Great! Because we’re here!”

As soon as they all tumbled out of the suit, Catra fell to her knees, hands clasped around her ears. Even Micah had turned slightly grey and sickly.

“We should go,” he stammered out, “no one comes back from this part of the island.”

“The signal is even better inside!”

“Inside where?” Adora asked, helping Catra struggle to her feet.

Entrapta pulled away a curtain of vinery, revealing a deep First One’s hall. It reminded her of the temple again, and she met eyes with Catra.

“Are you sure you’re okay?” She asked.

Catra nodded, “If you are.”

Adora pressed a kiss to her forehead, not even thinking, relief and fear pouring into it in equal measure. Catra even leaned in.

“Are you coming?” Entrapta asked and they blinked apart, King Micah was staring at them.

“Into the dark scary tunnel where we can all hear the source of the signal?” Bow asked.

Adora looked around, realizing they were all flinching back now. Everyone except her.

Sea Hawk put an arm around Bow’s shoulder. “Adventure!”

“Let’s get this over with,” Glimmer muttered, scowling as she started in.

Adora went hand in hand with Catra, feeling her heartbeat from her palm. At least she could still feel that.

“This is definitely a First One’s temple,” Adora muttered as they finally came into the atrium. At the far end was what could’ve only been described as Entrapta’s lab, a variety of computers hooked up to a pulsing source of data.

“When we met I was trying to unlock the secrets of this planet,” Entrapta dragged Adora forward as she pounded a few keys on the computer with her hair. “The First Ones tried to hide it by dumping it here, but I’ve finally found it. Everything I’ve been looking for or ever wanted to know!” She was tearing up, Adora realized. With joy.

The computer powered on and a steady stream of data zoomed upwards at speeds even Adora couldn’t parse together the dead language. More screens popped up and surrounded them and she tried to make out anything on those too.

“The First Ones retrofitted the planet with tech.” Entrapta bounced around, pressing buttons and pulling levers. “Trying to mine the magic at the center of the planet to power their weapon.”

“Their what?” Adora’s voice sounded so much smaller than expected.

“Their weapon!” Entrapta called, much louder. “And guess what else I discovered?”

She leaned way into Adora’s space, bouncing up and down as she did. “Um, what?”

“She-Ra is back!” Entrapta grinned.

“Yeah, I’m—I’m She-Ra.” Adora raised her chin and Entrapta’s eyes widened.

“When did you first transform?”

“Um, a couple of weeks ago?”

“Exactly when the computers powered on. My theory was correct. You must already know all about the weapon, seeing as you’re a part of it! What do you know about the signal, that’s the piece that’s so confusing to me. My working hypothesis is that because Shadow Weaver is connected to—“

“Hold on, back up,” Catra moved to stand next to her, “What do you mean that Adora’s part of the weapon? What weapon? What did the First Ones do to the planet?"

“Oh all the princesses are part of the weapon. At least all the ones with magic.” She bounced away, “Hang on, let me show you!” She swung up to the ceiling so she could be level with a massive screen.

The screen changed from its stream of data to a single glowing purple circle.

“The Heart of Etheria draws its power from the magic of the princesses,” Entrapta said. The planet appeared, translucent over the glowing purple circle. “It needs all their Runestones engaged for it to work.”

The five Runestones appeared at equal measures around the planet, lines cast down to the center.

A glowing golden She-Ra appeared over the planet, “And She-Ra is the most important piece, the key. She channels the weapon's power and focuses it.”

Adora stepped closer. Could this be her destiny? Could this be what she was looking for?

A screen cleared to her right and she jumped, a woman with dark hair and a golden crown was handed the sword, the power of the sword ripped into her arms, her eyes, making them glow pure white. She was in pain, suffering.

“She-Ra is the only being strong enough to withstand the destructive energy of the heart,” Entrapta continued.

Adora stared in horror at the screaming woman. Who was that?

“So, the First Ones made the sword to control her, to use her. When the heart is deployed She-Ra will raise the sword and fire it!” Adora turned away from the woman, her eyes burning, only to look at the main screen.

The mock model of Etheria expanded and exploded, and Adora gaped.

Entrapta let out a cackle.

“Entrapta what—what happens to Etheria if the weapon is deployed?” Adora asked.

Entrapta blinked at her, she pressed a button and the model showed itself again, the planet blowing itself to smithereens over and over again.

“Do I—do you not understand the concept of death? Do I need to explain that?” Her brow furrowed. “Do you know what life is?”

“So we all die?” Adora asked.

Entrapta nodded.

“But if,” Catra stepped closer, “If She-Ra is the key doesn’t that mean Adora can just—not fire it then?”

Adora looked at her, wondering what this new thing in her heart was. Catra looked back, eyes swimming with concern.

“Once the planet is balanced, no one can stop it. Not even the First Ones could control it! That’s why they left.” Entrapta slowly rose into the rafters of the building so she was balanced over Adora. “Once the weapon is activated it will channel all its power into you,” Entrapta grinned. “You don’t get to refuse.”

Adora pushed past her, pushed for breath but all she could see was that woman being handed that sword, watching her writhe in agony, watching the planet blow up again and again, words faster than she could read them running across the screens.

End, it said sometimes, and peace.

She looked down at the sword, she thought it was her destiny. It was just another thing people used to control her. Magic was just something to control her, hurt her.

“But Etheria isn’t balanced yet,” Bow put a hand on her shoulder. “Look! There’s still a runestone offline.”

“The Black Garnet,” Adora whispered.

“Yes,” Entrapta moved in front of her, “Shadow Weaver’s Runestone!"

“Who?” King Micah asked.

“The second in command at the Horde,” Entrapta bounced. “The Black Garnet is unique because it was the first Runestone the First One’s connected to. Their signal is almost identical to it. I was fascinated when I discovered the signal blocks out Shadow Weaver’s.”

“Shadow Weaver has a signal?” Adora asked, her heart dropping.

“Yes,” Entrapta cocked her head. “Of course? How do you think she was always tracking you? Why do you think her wounds always hurt even after they healed? It’s been my hypothesis ever since we met, you were spending too much time with me and—“

“What?” Adora’s voice cracked. “She did it all on purpose, she’s been hurting me, tracking me…”

“That’s how she found us on the ship,” Catra whispered. “And that’s why you haven’t been in pain.”

“Wait a second,” King Micah stepped forward, “who gave you those scars?”

Catra stepped in front of Adora. “Dad, not the time.”

“Her name was Shadow Weaver,” Adora said. “She was the sorceress for the Horde.”

“Did she have scars all over her face?” He asked.

Adora blinked, “I—I only saw them once. How did you—”

“I was the one who gave them to her,” he said, he stepped up to the screen. “We can’t let her have the power of the Black Garnet. She’s a monster.”

“If you do that we can connect Force Captain Scorpia to her Runestone! Then the weapon can activate!” Entrapta added helpfully.

His face fell. “What?” He turned back to Entrapta, “No. There has to be another way. That woman cannot be given any power, you don’t know what she’s capable of.”

Adora swallowed hard. “That’s why I never heard the signal at this island, right Entrapta?” Entrapta looked at her. “It's because Shadow Weaver’s was always in my head.”

She nodded, taking notes on a pad of paper she pulled from nowhere, “I thought that would happen.”

“In your head?” King Micah studied Adora, “What do you mean she was in your head?”

“The only way we can save the planet is if Shadow Weaver keeps her power,” Adora realized, her stomach sinking.

“No,” Catra took her hand, “No way am I letting that happen. We’ll destroy that Runestone if we have to.”

“Then the weapon would destabilize and explode,” Entrapta added.

“We’ll figure something else out,” Catra stepped in front of Entrapta so Adora was forced to focus on her. “I’m not gonna let her hurt you.”

Adora shook her head. “We need to make sure this weapon never activates.”

“Uh crew,” Sea Hawk spoke up, “Not to interrupt your emotional adventure but I don’t think this temple wants us to leave.”

Vines were curling up the wall and Adora pulled her sword from her shackle, on instinct. For the first time since touching it, it felt wrong in her hands. She felt weaker for using it.

“Time to go,” Adora swallowed hard. “Entrapta how long will it take you to pack up?”

“Oh I’m not leaving!” Entrapta smiled. “But come visit again soon.”

“Nope,” Adora grabbed her under the waist, holding her sideways. “You’re coming back to Bright Moon because I’m not leaving you behind again.”

“Hey!” Entrapta struggled. “Can I at least grab a memory core?”

“Nope!” She ran, towards the door, where Micah was summoning a spell. She flinched in spite of herself.

“Ooh, Adora is your startle response related to—”

“Entrapta, I will tape your mouth shut.”

“You have tape? Can I have some?”

“This way!” King Micah called, as he led them out of the temple. “We’ll have to head for the shore!”

“And then what?” Catra demanded. “We make a swim for it?”

“You got any other ideas?” Glimmer asked.

“At least we’ll have some time to regroup,” Bow said. “Now move, people!”

“I can’t swim,” Sea Hawk moaned but even he started running for the exit.

Adora drew her sword with one hand, the other hand still holding Entrapta under her arm, and cut away at the vines chasing them.

She stopped short as she reached the exit, pooka closing in on them.

Micah fought them off with his magic, summoning fire to blast at them. Was Shadow Weaver able to do that? Where did it come from? Could she ever run out?

“Ow, fuck!” A pooka had latched itself on Catra’s leg, and Adora twisted the sword into a staff, slamming it into the pooka's face. Blood seeped from the wound, even as the pooka fell to its death.

“Are you okay?”

“No! Fuck!” Catra grabbed Adora’s shirt, grasping it as she struggled on one leg.

“Okay, okay,” Adora swallowed, “we’ll get you to safety.” She looked around the battle, everyone struggling and separated. “Bow, take Entrapta!”

“I don’t want him touching me,” Entrapta informed her.

Adora gritted her teeth, “Then—”

“I’ve got her,” Bow looped an arm under Catra, shooting Adora a smile. He looked back at Catra. “Please don’t bite me.”

“I make no promises,” Catra muttered.

“Sea Hawk, Glimmer get them some cover,” Adora shouted out. “Your majesty, you and I should hold them off and loop back later.”

“I’m not leaving you behind,” Glimmer said, grabbing her dad’s hand.

“Your friend is right, the less of us there are the more likely we’ll be able to slip through undetected. Now run!”

“Glimmer, go,” Adora ordered, Glimmer looked back at her and Adora held her sword a little tighter, “I’ll get him back safe and sound. I promise.”

She gave a last nod before following the other group.

“Pooka incoming!” Entrapta called and Adora swung the sword at it. “I figured with your eye missing you might have a decreased field of vision.”

“Gonna be my eyes, Entrapta?” Adora asked, swinging her sword again as a group of pookas tried to follow the larger prey.

“Okay! One o’clock!”

Three pooka down.

“I can probably build you a bionic eye, you know.”

Adora pulled King Micah out of the fray as he stumbled and took on five pooka.

“We need to keep moving, we bought as much time as we could,” he wheezed.

“You go, I’ll catch up,” Adora told him. One launched at her face, hissing directly at her, and she let out a scream, pulling it off her face and catapulting it off the cliff. “On second thought, let’s go!”

The three of them began a mad dash for the shore, Adora bringing down branches behind them as she ran, hoping to slow down the pooka.

“You’re dating my daughter,” King Micah called as they ran.

“Uh.”

“I know it’s not the best time, but she seems happy,” He continued. “I feel like she was my little girl just yesterday. I think if anyone was good enough for her, it’d have to be She-Ra.”

Adora swallowed hard. She-Ra was a weapon of mass destruction. If anyone was good enough for Catra, She-Ra would be last on the list.

“And I’m sorry about Shadow Weaver,” he said. “She won’t get away with it.”

A whistle let through the air that sounded suspiciously like “we say yo ho but we don’t say ho,” and Adora dragged King Micah behind a rock as the horde of pooka kept running.

“Are you guys okay?” Glimmer asked, taking her dad's hand.

“Are you?” Adora looked at Catra, leaning against the rock like she wasn’t sweating too much.

“I knew you would recognize the whistle!” Sea Hawk said. “The others doubted but I knew you listened to my shanty!”

“Fascinating,” Entrapta cut in. “Adora, do you like shanties now? I thought they didn’t have music in the Horde.”

“We found a shortcut,” Catra said. “We should keep moving.”

“Entrapta, can you walk?” Adora asked.

Entrapta frowned but extricated herself from under Adora’s arm. “I still don’t see why you couldn’t have left me behind. The signal didn’t bother me. There's so much to learn from this island!”

“You can come back once we get you a pair of industrial-strength earplugs okay?” Adora said. “But I need your help first.”

“It’s really cool to meet you Entrapta,” Bow held out a hand. “I’m a bit of a maker myself. I made these arrows,” he showed off one of them and she quickly took it apart with her hair.

“Oooooh.”

“You two can, um, get to know each other.” Adora ran after Catra, who had already started limping along. “Hey, hey can you slow down?”

Catra turned on her, “Don’t do that again.”

“Do what?” Adora stepped back.

Catra looked around them but with Sea Hawk and Bow glued to each other, and Entrapta glued to Bow’s bow, and Glimmer glaring at them from her spot next to King Micah, they were pretty much alone.

“You did the whole sacrifice yourself thing, for my dad,” Catra hissed. “You can’t just jump off whatever cliff is conveniently around!”

Adora blinked, “I don’t—you told me to! You told me to keep an eye out for them. We had this whole conversation.”

“I told you to keep an eye on Glimmer, my baby sister. Not one of the most powerful sorcerers alive who is an adult man!”

“And is also your father.” Catra flinched and Adora felt a rush of pride, knowing she had figured it out. “It’s okay to be angry with him you know. It’s okay to not know how you feel.”

Catra tripped over something and Adora grabbed her by the arm, keeping her upright. Catra ripped her hand away.

“I don’t want to talk about him, I want to talk about you.”

“Catra, you can’t avoid this forever,” Adora said. “I’m here for you.”

“No, I'm here for you!” Catra groaned, “Dammit Adora! You just found out Shadow Weaver has still been hurting you, and we can’t take her out. Stop focusing on me for five seconds!”

Adora froze.

Well, physically she kept walking, but she was also frozen solid.

Sounds around her were muted, sensations, everything, it was like she was existing outside of herself. She only knew she was alive because occasionally she felt a heartbeat, heard an intake of breath.

A hand landed in hers again, another hand forced her to make eye contact with Catra. Mismatched eyes to mismatched eyes.

“Hey,” Catra’s words were so much quieter than they should’ve been. “I promised to look out for you, right? We’ll figure something out. Adora I—I care about you.”

Adora shook her head and kept moving, half tempted to rip her hand away from Catra’s. But she didn’t and from the way Catra’s thumb swiped over hers she could tell it was appreciated. She’d get a handle on this eventually, whatever they were. They’d be okay.

They broke through the woods and Adora instantly squeezed Catra's hand, the pain increasing tenfold. Adora glanced behind her, waiting for pooka to descend, or forest vines to reach up. Despite everything this island had taken from her she'd still miss not feeling like her leg was about to fall off constantly. Maybe King Micah would be able to cure her, maybe she really did have a chance.

"Look Adora," Catra whispered and Adora looked up, staring at the giant ship waiting for them. A young woman stepped off as they approached, soldiers following her beck and call.

"My darling princess Mermista!" They heard Sea Hawk call. He took off in a sprint and hopped in her arms and she glared at him, though didn't drop him.

"Princess Mermista," Catra raised a hand. Princess Mermista looked at Catra with a pained expression.

"Crap."

Catra narrowed her eyes but Adora was looking around at some of the soldiers. They weren't all Salineas. Some of them were Rebellion.

"Axe?" Bow stepped forward to a group of them and one of them turned around.

"Bow?" Axe rushed him pulling him into a crushing hug, "Thank god!"

Catra had stationed Axe in Salineas to defend the seagate, per the queen's orders. The more she looked around the more Rebellion uniforms she counted. A good amount of his battalion must've tagged along.

"What are you doing here?" Catra demanded, coming to the same conclusion. "With the princess and you gone, Salineas will be an easy target. I gave you an order."

Axe pulled away from Bow, eyes wide, “Commander—I—it’s you.” He took them all in, Adora, Glimmer, and King Micah. “Your Majesty?”

King Micah straightened. “Please, I’m in your debt! How did you all know to come search for us?”

“You’re alive?” Axe gaped.

“Evidently,” Catra looked between them. “Why did you break rank? Did my mom—”

“I came to find you,” Axe looked at Catra, “There’s a—there’s a search out for you. I ran into Princess Mermista while I was looking and she said she got a tip from a seagull and…”

Sea Hawk puffed out his chest and Mermista dropped him, glaring.

“Here you are,” Axe continued, voice quiet. Not quiet as in awed but quiet in a sickeningly familiar way. Adora’s stomach began to sink. She knew this song better than anyone.

“Figures, we lose our tracker pad for three days and my mom sends a manhunt,” Catra growled, crossing her arms. “It’s gonna take months for us to regain this ground—“

“Commander.”

Axe had never interrupted Catra before, no one interrupted Catra. That cinched it. Adora squeezed Catra’s hand, Catra didn’t even notice.

“It wasn’t the queen,” Axe said, “It was General Juliet.”

“Why would—”

“There was—I’m sorry,” Axe put a hand on Bow’s shoulder, “The queen is dead.”

“What?” Catra asked.

Someone fell to the ground, but Adora couldn’t rightly say who. Her eyes didn’t leave Catra’s face, though Catra’s hand began to sweat in hers.

“You’re to be queen,” Axe said.

“What?” Catra asked.

Adora didn’t let go.

Chapter End Notes

man this was a long one! Can you believe this was gonna be 6 chapters? It might've even been 8! But it's done! thank god!

I'm sure you have lots of questions but hopefully this answered a few of them too!

A lot of your answers will be answered in the next story but a lot of them won't be too. You might have to wait until the last installment :(

but I do have three one shots coming out before the next story! The first one will be up today, the second one will come out sometime next week, probably Sunday or Monday, and the third one will come out a weekish after that one. I still have to write that one lol.

if you want to come scream to me about how terrible i am you can find me on tumblr at @womenlovingwonderwoman and find all the content relating to this story on the tag bid my mother

but a huge shoutout to iamascret who helped edit this monster and even looked at the one shot that's about to go up which i don't usually ask her to do. you can find her on tumblr at @iamascret. she's a great writer and you should

read her stories tbh. and not just cause her beta is fun and sexy and cool.

please leave a comment it writes 500 words and as you can tell there is so much that still needs to be written. krejkjdfg why did i sign up for this.

people have yet to get the shanty reference, i'm gonna say you should look up the lyrics, but please don't spoil it for anyone in the comments, 50 additional words to whoever gets it without looking it up!

End Notes

I know notes at both ends are frowned upon but i just want y'all to know this fic will take a long time to finish. I have a super demanding job that will only get more demanding (I'm working 80 hr work days and I have no idea how long it'll last) and these updates might be sporadic. However. I do know where I want to go, how I want to do this, and as long as y'all keep commenting I'll keep writing 500 words! So comment.

Also huge shoutouts to @iamasecret for the help with the synopsis, the outline, the chapter and the moral encouragement.
and of course @lexascandelstores for reading this chapter. happy monday man.

you can find @iamasecret's ao3 here and her fic that i am currently bettaing here. if you like pacific rim and she-ra and also idiot lesbians who can't communicate you'll love total synergistics

you can find @lexascandlestore's a03 here where she writes gay warrior nun fanfic that kills me.

And of course you can find me on tumblr here. Drop an ask if you want some HCs or some fic recs bc if you've ever clicked on my author name you'll see ive read everything ever.

also you'll have yet to guess the shanty sea hawk is singing. that's another 500 words if you do (but no cheating)

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!